

IMAGEM&VER(A)CIDADE

URBAN ARTWORKS AND THEIR DIGITAL COUNTERPARTS

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Rio de Janeiro, 2012

English translation, 2026

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Monograph presented to the Institute of Arts of UERJ
as a requirement for the degree of Bachelor in Art History

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Rio de Janeiro, 2012

Abstract

Starting from current works of urban art, above all those linked to the graffiti tradition, we propose here a reflection on the relations between image and space in the context of digital technology. The plurality of means and devices in Banksy's work, and the animations mixing 2D techniques with stop-motion in the urban landscape by the artist Blu, will be the objects of more extended analysis, even though other artists will also serve as guides to deepen this line of thought. These relations and contexts are also extremely important for indicating recent tendencies in the production and reception of artworks — tendencies that may open original paths in the contemporary narrative of art history.

Translator's note: the title is kept in the original Portuguese, since "Ver(a)cidade" is a wordplay that cannot be carried into English. It condenses three readings at once: veracidade (veracity, truthfulness), ver a cidade (to see the city), and cidade (the city) itself — an English approximation would be something like "Image & the truth of seeing the city." This translation was prepared in 2026 by Claude (Anthropic) at the author's request; figures are reproduced from the original PDF.

Introduction

Let us begin with a personal story, since this research was developed interwoven with the experience of practical projects, with my own life among those who make art in the streets. I was seventeen when I learned that a friend of my boyfriend at the time was making stencils around the streets; by then I was already studying art history on my own and was passionate about painting in oil and watercolor. When I saw this acquaintance's paintings I found the drawing interesting, even if it did not impress me — yet our mutual friends were astonished by the works made in the street, saying they were brilliant. I was surprised by this reaction, above all from people I kept trying to bring along to art exhibitions, who rarely showed any enthusiasm for them. It was then explained to me that what was interesting about the street paintings was not so much our friend's drawing itself, but the way the paintings related to the landscape: the surprise of passersby, the site, the act of aesthetically dignifying a wall we normally barely looked at.

From then on I decided I would make a project of my own in this direction, since working with the street as an artistic support seemed to hold many possibilities worth exploring. I thought of doing something that would relate to the history of whatever site I chose. I imagined: if the architecture of a city allows several eras to coexist, why not create paintings with a touch of illusion, through which the inhabitants would come to live alongside citizens of other times? It seemed to me a beautiful way of interacting with the chosen place, of making work that would mean more than my daily routine in a studio — work that would reach beyond the interests of art alone, mixing into one project my interest in history and sociology. Especially after entering an Art History program, I realized I could no longer produce works without being conscious of the spaces and media I used to make them; the framing of the work or project had to make sense. The study of institutional critique, together with an understanding of how art institutions function, was among the strongest discoveries of my undergraduate years, and it was for a course on those subjects that I wrote my first academic paper on urban art — specifically, on Banksy.

My first project linked to the production of urban art was called “Urban Images — Looking at Morro da Conceição,” part of my undergraduate research fellowship under the supervision of Roberto Conduru (to whom I will always be immensely grateful for suggesting the ideal site for realizing the ideas I had at that moment). Other essential help at this stage came from the historical tips, suggestions of places, and even bibliography offered by Rafael Cardoso, an art historian living in Morro da Conceição, and from the family photographs of Paulo Dalier, an eighty-year-old artist who has lived in that area since childhood. The project consisted of painting imaginary, life-size figures of characters from other eras in the streets, mixing the everyday life of the past (converted into image as it is imagined today) with the everyday life of the present, thereby proposing a reflection on the construction of local identities and

memories and their insertion into the global network of images. The inhabitants of the place I chose for my interventions were very receptive; it was easier than I had imagined to convince shop owners to let me paint their walls, and their involvement in the project left me deeply satisfied. From my first painting onward — a *preto velho* directly suggested by the owner of a marble workshop — I invited a professional photographer, Magno Mesquita, to document the action, and he used the opportunity to produce his own artistic work about my process. Later, since the children of the area kept gathering around me, I began lending them my camera, so that the documentation photos were taken by the residents themselves, giving me another perspective on their interaction with the project. Readings of Roland Barthes, Douglas Crimp, and Walter Benjamin were essential references for thinking about photography during this phase.

I did not quite know what the research photographs might mean when I started; I imagined documentation was essential, but my medium was painting, which I regarded as a more markedly subjective process of looking at / imagining the past. Yet as soon as the first paintings were finished, I could watch the passersby — children above all — having great fun taking pictures next to my images: this gesture of photographing oneself interacting with the painting seemed an essential element in the enjoyment of the work. I was even surprised to come across a photograph in an exhibition at Caixa Cultural Rio de Janeiro organized by Walter Firmo in 2011, showing a woman posing with my painting of a *malandro*. At the same time, I myself was constantly publicizing the project on my Facebook profile, and since I left no signature on the walls, some people only discovered my authorship through the internet. By that point I could already see that my focus at the end of the research fellowship would no longer be street painting as such, but something addressing the question of the image in a broader way.

Going to France on an exchange program, I encountered a completely different urban art scene — riskier, where painting in public space during the day was not common, and where the interaction with the city was of another kind, in a certain sense more formal. French friends even asked me to paint their outer wall, but they never got past the first stage of their borough's bureaucracy to obtain the required written authorization. So I made a project similar to the one developed in Rio de Janeiro, but since it had to be illegal, I worked with paste-ups, installing them at five in the morning and filming everything. Documentation gained even more weight in this project, because by the next day some pieces had already been torn off or altered, and most of the people who saw these works knew them only through the photographs and video I made available online, on Facebook or my blog.

Traveling through São Paulo, London, Istanbul, Rome, Buenos Aires, Asunción, Fortaleza, and other cities, I had the chance to see different urban art scenes, but it was the Berlin scene that most caught my attention as a place where techniques and

approaches mixed, in painting and in other street interventions. There were entire building façades painted; many paste-up interventions scattered through the details of the city; it was the first time I saw Magda Sayeg's knitting mounted on public monuments; and I could closely observe large-scale murals by Osgemeos and by Blu, whose work I had first seen at an international animation festival at MAM-RJ in 2008. If my research turned more and more toward the relation between image and space, my contact with these works and with the diversity of production in the urban scene — which I knew both physically and through websites — was among the factors that drove it in that direction.

Back in Rio de Janeiro, I came to know the urban art scene in greater depth — not only the artists tied to art institutions, public calls, and gallery projects, but also the scene generally called graffiti, as well as *pichação*. Although my personal path and position differ from those who usually call themselves *grafiteiros*, I came to be recognized as one as soon as I used spray paint on a wall open to public view, and in the end I grew close to the others. I am involved in art production in several ways beyond research and the practice of painting: I work at Rede Nami (a nonprofit that fights for women's rights through urban art projects); I have worked for the samba school Pimpolhos da Grande Rio; I live in a house with a design studio (Estúdio Pira); I take part in Rio's fine arts scene; and I am part of a book publishing house created by my family, Viajante do Tempo, focused on interdisciplinary educational projects. I believe this life across several milieus was also essential to developing my outlook and research process — the fruit of the bibliography of books and websites recommended or discovered, as much as of the conversations, exchanges, and experiences with the people who crossed my path.

Of the many artists I could have chosen — some of whom I know personally and could have questioned about their work — the production of two foreign men I have never met became my focus for the reflective development of this monograph. The works of many others will also be cited and analyzed in the chapters that follow, but of Banksy and Blu I can say they were my guides. I believe that grappling with their processes is illuminating — or at least that it is their works that render my hypotheses and observations most clearly. Both began within the scene called graffiti and remain in some way connected to it, but their works unfold the possibilities of working space as image for an observer of the digital era in very particular ways, which serve as bridges for my analyses. I could have chosen artists and collectives whose work in public space is more evidently based on the use of new technologies — projectors and mobile phones, for instance — as is the case with some artists I admire: Miguel Chevalier, Simone Michelin, or the Graffiti Research Lab. If I preferred to turn mainly to artists whose working medium is centered on painting, it is out of personal identification, and because I wanted to show that even when artists do not use expensive or specialized technological devices, their practice can be bound to the digital medium in the way it produces meaning — across several instances of its production, diffusion,

and reception.

The first chapter of this work presents the general idea of the research, asking about the relations between art production in physical space — in this case, the city — and the digital medium. Who is the observer of these works, and in what way would their perception differ from that of someone who does not combine so many functions simultaneously, being at once internet user, spectator, and reader?

The second chapter turns to a reflection on cities, which proves necessary in order to deepen the very concept of urban art and its connections with the sphere of the internet. I also address the history and diffusion of the practice of artistic interventions, above all street paintings, in recent decades, to indicate how the digital era may have influenced these activities.

The third chapter focuses on the work of Banksy — on how he uses the street as a space of contestation and a strategic site for drawing attention to his own work. The plurality of his means and his connection with pop culture and pop art open perspectives for thinking about ways of approaching urban space.

Chapter four analyzes works that make clear how technologies can blend urban art with digital art, or conceive of an observer within the process of virtualization we are living through.

The title of this work came from the name, conceived by Ruy Sampaio, of an exhibition in which I will participate as an artist — and which I also helped organize — to be held in October 2012 at Caixa Cultural Rio de Janeiro.

Chapter 1 — Imagem&Ver(a)cidade

“The city is no longer the political-industrial polygon it was in the nineteenth century; it is the polygon of signs, of media, of code.” — Jean Baudrillard¹



Fig. 1 — 2008, Banksy, spray paint on wall, approx. 2.5 m × 1.80 m, London — current location undisclosed.

The story goes that on a Sunday morning, January 6, 2008, a crew set up enormous scaffolding in front of the white wall of the Portobello Post company on Portobello Road in West London — a well-known street, with its Victorian-era houses, extremely busy on weekends because of its open-air markets. Few people seem to have found the scaffolding strange; some residents reportedly asked the supposed workmen what it was about, but after a somewhat vague answer did not press the matter. A few hours later, the crew and the scaffolding having left the site, passersby were surprised to see a black-and-white stencil on the wall, portraying a painter in traditional dress holding a palette, touching up red letters in the typical style of graffiti tags. One could read the name of the author of the infraction: Banksy (fig. 1).

The story also goes that as soon as he learned what had happened, the owner of the post-production company Portobello Post, Luti Fagbenle, had the piece protected with a thick acetate sheet fixed with screws — a practice that has become common in that city whenever a graffiti work is suspected to be by a very well-known author; after all, if it is not protected it may soon be erased or tagged over. A few days later, after a statement by a representative of Banksy attesting to the work's authenticity, the painting was being auctioned on eBay, and within a week it had received more than

¹BAUDRILLARD, Jean. “Kool Killer, or the Insurrection by Signs,” translated [into Portuguese] by Fernando Mesquita. *Revista Cinema/Cine Olho*, n. 5, Jul/Aug 1979.

seventy bids, reaching the price of 208,100 dollars.² An astonishing price for a work made illegally, in a city where this kind of urban intervention is considered a crime, where many paintings by this same artist have been erased — and at times still are. The final buyer also had to pay an additional 5,000 dollars to remove the artwork from the wall.

I narrate the story by saying what “is told,” even though this is based on different newspapers, such as the BBC, The Guardian, and The Times,³ because with this urban artist it always seems possible that one of his actions is part of a hoax, in the manner of Orson Welles’s film *F for Fake*. If this was already sketched in the many controversies about his identity, and became even clearer after he opened a fake pet shop in New York and released his pseudo-documentary *Exit Through the Gift Shop* in 2010 (nominated for that year’s Oscar for best documentary, despite all the controversy over the truthfulness of its narrative), the public came to realize that one can hardly be certain of what one knows about Banksy. Hiding behind this pseudonym, this artist — possibly a collective of artists — managed to propel a phenomenon of visibility and price appreciation for a generation of urban artists, most of whom began working in the 1990s, and who are now often grouped under the name *street art* or *post-graffiti* — not a coherent movement, nor even a phenomenon restricted to one place, and these names are hardly unanimous.⁴

But if we look attentively at the stencil-graffiti for which Banksy originally became known, we will hardly find such striking originality of technique or visual solutions in them. After all, there is no shortage of precedents for his nearly black-and-white images and his quickly legible political satire: in the 1980s and 90s there is the direct influence of Blek le Rat; in the 1970s, Richard Hambleton; and looking further back one can find many other examples. Yet if we consider Banksy’s more recent production, we are no longer speaking only of painting on walls. Whether the quality of Banksy’s painting and critique reaches an intensity comparable to Andy Warhol — with whom he is frequently compared and to whom he himself alludes directly — is something to be considered carefully; but if this artist has stirred such commotion, above all in the last seven or eight years, it was not only because of his paintings, but above all because of the way he knew how to diffuse them and to create controversy with them. The comparison between Banksy and Warhol seems well-founded, not only because of the countless iconographic references the former makes to the latter through his works (such as the 2005 prints of Kate Moss resembling Warhol’s Marilyn), but because of the shared interest in playing with the logic of consumer society through different devices. It is the plurality of this artist’s work, and the way

²Information from the BBC website: <http://news.bbc.co.uk/2/hi/entertainment/7188387.stm>. Other sources state the price reached 400,000 dollars (<http://ezinearticles.com/?5-Most-Expensive-Banksy-ArtPieces&id=6065536>).

³See bibliography.

⁴There are several references to the “Banksy Effect” and to his works; a good source that gathers this information succinctly is the Wikipedia entry on the artist: <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Banksy>

he manages to draw attention to his image while keeping strong control over it, that interest this text.

For each of his projects, the artist creates a different website which not only publicizes what has been done but attests to the authenticity of new works and makes its own combinations of photographic framings and short texts. In 2009 the artist launched the site Pest Control (<http://www.pestcontroloffice.com>), to which internet users interested in buying or selling one of his works can send several photos of the desired piece so that they may be analyzed, earning a certificate of authenticity if the work is recognized as original. After all, once his works began to be sold at Sotheby's and reached considerable sums, situations like the one with the Portobello Road piece became frequent, creating the need to control the artist's production available on the art market. Moreover, many fake works bearing the artist's mark circulate on the market and — more curious still — many fake websites sell his works or merchandise (mugs, shirts, customized prints, and so on).

It would be mistaken to separate what is happening in the streets from its virtual counterpart. As Néstor García Canclini points out with regard to readers, spectators, and internet users,⁵ these cultural receivers are concentrated in the same person, and the cultural industries are uniting languages and combining spaces in a technological process of digital convergence. One of Canclini's examples: the Time group, dedicated to print media, merged with the visual mega-producer Warner, and together — already one of the largest manufacturers of spectacles and content — they allied in 2000 with an enormous internet producer, AOL. In a similar way, it is these huge companies that populate not only the media but also urban space with their countless advertisements, turning every setting into a place of buying and selling. Like Jean Baudrillard's polygon of signs, media, and code, or Michel de Certeau's labyrinth of images,⁶ the city becomes a landscape of posters organizing our reality, showing the

For Canclini, the internet user would then be a multimedia agent who reads, listens, and combines diverse materials drawn from reading and from spectacles; following this line of thought, one sees that this internet-user-reader-spectator is also the observer of urban art. Here one should remember that the most effective form of publicizing recent street artworks has been virtual — blogs and sites such as the well-known Wooster Collective. If graffiti, and later so-called street art (or urban art, for those who criticize the other term), initially gained visibility through its massive occupation of the street, artists working in this medium today know very well the importance of photographing and filming their art. They do so because of the ephemerality inherent in much street work, but also because they know their work gains another

⁵CANCLINI, Néstor. *Leitores, Espectadores e Internautas*. São Paulo: Iluminuras, 2008.

⁶CERTEAU, Michel de. *A cultura no plural*. São Paulo: Papirus, 1995. repertoire of our imminent happinesses. Not only Banksy but so many other current urban artists, and the websites that publicize them, strongly attack the apparent omnipresence of advertising in the streets, placing in it one of the great motivations for what they consider to be the current proliferation of urban art.

kind of force through digital repercussion. In these virtual galleries (websites, or simply a Google image search) where all images seem within reach, it is possible to connect works made in extremely distant places across the globe, using the photographic framing of the work and its context as a way of creating narratives; it is possible to make maps of cities from works suggested for visiting; it is even possible to fabricate a plausible non-place through digital alteration of the images.

At this point we begin to glimpse another very curious question: some works of urban art are only completed in the media. But what final images are these? “What is an image? The proliferating multiplication of images in our contemporary world seems — therein lies its paradox — inversely proportional to our capacity to say with exactness what they correspond to.”⁷ We are bombarded with images every day; they are everywhere, in a way that was impossible before the facilities of technical reproduction — a way that ends up changing how we see and interpret them.

Vilém Flusser attempts to explain the difference between what he calls technical images and traditional images, a difference that would mark an entire epistemological turn we are said to be undergoing. For this thinker, traditional images are based on man’s perception of the four basic dimensions of reality (width, depth, height, and time), from which they abstract two (depth and time), transforming the perceived circumstance into a two-dimensional scene. Technical images, by contrast, are the result of apparatuses that are themselves the product of the application of scientific texts, whose origins go back to images “torn” into lines (“one-dimensionality”); the apparatuses are thus projections of the logical-mathematical linearity of their texts. Technical images are therefore not based directly on human perception of reality; they are formed of countless points that will suggest the dimensions of reality — but since they are points, the image ultimately resides in “zero-dimensionality.”⁸ Flusser presents the development of man’s capacities for abstraction in the production of images and texts within a model he considers phenomenological — a model that does not claim general validity and is merely a supporting hook, since it can be deceptively linear. What matters for our reflection is how he stresses that technical images, inversely to traditional images, spring from a gesture that moves from the abstract toward the concrete.

⁷ALLOA, Emmanuel. *Penser l’image*. Paris: Les presses du réel, 2010, p. 7. “Qu’est-ce qu’une image? La multiplication proliférante des images dans notre monde contemporain semble — c’est là son paradoxe — inversement proportionnelle à notre faculté de dire avec exactitude à quoi elles correspondent” (author’s free translation).

⁸FLUSSER, Vilém. *O universo das imagens técnicas* [The Universe of Technical Images]. São Paulo: Annablume, 2008, p. 17: “The traditional image is produced by a gesture that abstracts depth from the circumstance, that is, by a gesture that moves from the concrete toward the abstract. The techno-image is produced by a gesture that regroups points to form surfaces, that is, by a gesture that moves from the abstract toward the concrete.”



Figs. 2 and 3 — 2005, Mark Jenkins, Storker Project, photographs of adhesive-tape sculptures in public spaces, Washington (USA) and Bethlehem (Palestine).

And does this ever-stronger abstraction in our way of appropriating and perceiving space not change our way of thinking it? What space is this, to be populated with images and to appear reflected in countless other images? If Banksy already combines works of his own — some with site-specific characteristics — presenting a collection of photographs from various places around the globe in his own virtual museum, other artists develop projects in which a distinctive relation to space through these technical images becomes more evident. Mark Jenkins, for example, a North American artist born in 1970, with his urban installations usually taking the form of figure sculptures, shows his various projects through photos identified by the place where they were made. A name for each work is not even necessary. On his website, the artist organizes his portfolio under the categories *city*, *nature*, and *inside*, and in the first two the only specification beneath each image is the city where it was made — from Rio de Janeiro to Seoul, Moscow, Washington, Bethlehem, among many others. In some projects, such as “Storker” (<http://www.xmarkjenkinsx.com/storker.html>, figs. 2 and 3), he goes so far as to place identical or similar sculptures in different cities, so that the interaction with the landscape becomes what differentiates each image. In the *inside* category, with works inside institutional spaces, nothing is written beneath each photo.

Yet there are many other ways of unfolding the relation between digital counterparts and plastic works realized in urban space. Blu is an Italian said to have been born in Bologna, and like Banksy and other artists of the same milieu today, he too hides behind his pseudonym. He does not turn his anonymity into controversy; he simply

emphasizes that he prefers to maintain his discretion. Active in the streets since 1999, and another artist who apparently loves to travel the globe leaving enormous murals in different cities, Blu distinguishes himself from other muralists by his interest in animation and in developing new techniques. He began with 2D animations in 2001, but around 2006–2008 he developed a very particular style of urban painting and animation: the artist paints a figure on a wall, takes a photo, then paints the figure with a slightly different movement next to the original and covers the previous one with white paint, leaving a trace of its lines — a mixture of stop-motion animation⁹ with traditional 2D (fig. 4). It is as if he made his oneiric reality live within the urban landscape; his characters interact with doors, windows, cars, pipes, pathways, and passersby. His first short released in this style, *Muto*, is a phenomenon of visibility on youtube.com, reaching 10 million views on its main link alone, and it has also taken part in several international animation festivals.



Fig. 4 — 2006, BLU, *Muto*, stop-motion animation, 7:26 min, filmed in Buenos Aires and Baden.

Earlier mixtures of animation and urban space made drawings in sequences which, if

⁹“Stop motion is the animation technique in which the animator works by photographing objects frame by frame. Between one frame and the next, the animator slightly changes the position of the objects. When the film is projected at 24 frames per second, we have the illusion that the objects are moving.” — <http://www.eba.ufmg.br/midiaarte/quadroaquadro/stop/princip1.htm#intro>

seen quickly from inside a vehicle, created a moving image, as in certain advertisements used in subways.¹⁰ There have also been cases of animations projected onto city walls, even making a character move through several streets using a projector inside a vehicle, as Vjsuave did recently, in 2011, in São Paulo. But the final images of Blu's videos are quite peculiar; the photo-painting technique yields a distinctive, easily recognizable effect. What impresses at first is simply the awareness of how many paintings were made to produce some five minutes of film — the sense that the walls of a city can become an animator's sheets of paper, forming the frames of movement. In the various videos the Italian has released, the spectator finds himself following not-quite-clear stories of men, machines, and monsters in a continuous process of transformation — often violent, with one being devouring or exploding another — always in a markedly linear drawing tending toward caricature, which so often lends a comic or absurd aspect to scenes of destruction.

What presence and what image in the context of the city are these artists after? Neither of the two renounces works that, as murals, have a great impact on the street, even reaching monumental sizes. Even so, we can no longer think of their works as based on an auratic presence; they escape that. After all, drawing on Jonathan Crary's thought about a possible history of vision — or rather, of the plural forces and rules that compose the field in which perception occurs — I think of the multifaceted observer who perceives such works, remembering that the artist too is an observer. As Crary says of the camera obscura in the eighteenth century and the stereoscope in the nineteenth, the observer and the various technologies linked to vision should not be understood as wholly distinct entities with separate identities. Our visual understanding would always be shaped by the apparatuses that create and transmit images, as well as by the epistemological conceptions of an era — ideas Crary exemplifies by stressing the impossibility of a theory of pure visibility in the eighteenth century. We would then be living, in the twenty-first century, through another period of transformation in the modes of looking, insofar as the means of producing and viewing images are undergoing rapid change — and here again it is worth recalling Flusser's concept of zero-dimensionality. I believe that through the works of such artists one can think the possibilities of imagining and acting in the city today — trajectories that point to a relation between work and space very different from, for example, Mexican muralism, with the large, planned paintings made in open parks by Diego Rivera, or public monuments executed on government commission and generally tied to the institutionalization of the city's memory — both examples based on an above all in-person enjoyment by the observer.

¹⁰In 2011, for example, the sporting goods brand Centauro placed a series of stickers in the tunnels of the Rio de Janeiro Metro, producing a stop-motion effect between the Uruguaiana and Catete stations.

Chapter 2 — The City and Its Images

Being one more among the many imaginary cities of the writer Italo Calvino in *Invisible Cities*, Cecilia is an illustrious city in which a goatherd loses his way with his goats. Marco Polo — himself a fictional character built upon a historical individual, endowed with the insatiable power of mentally roaming and narrating the entire empire of the great Kublai Khan — tries to orient the man, who, understanding only pastures, is incapable of finding his way in a city. Years later, however, Marco, having crossed so many continents and cities, finally loses his own way and asks an old man where he is: to his surprise the man replies that they are, unfortunately, in Cecilia, which the old man has been trying to leave for years without success — he is the same goatherd as before, aged now, his goats scrawny. But how could Polo have arrived in Cecilia if he was so far away? The spaces have mixed together, the other replies: “Cecilia is everywhere; here must once have been the Meadow of the Low Sage. My goats recognize the grasses of the median strip.”¹¹

Cecilia is catalogued by Marco Polo as one of the continuous cities, like Trude — another city with nothing special about it, but which the character cannot leave, for in the end all the others would be identical: the world would be covered by a single Trude, with only the airport’s name changing. These continuous cities are one of the many types of fictional metropolises narrated in *Invisible Cities* — cities that are nothing more than dreams, narrative developments around desires or fears, even though they seem the fruit of the rational mind and of chance. For Italo Calvino himself, this is the book in which he was able to say the most, perhaps because he managed to concentrate all his reflections, experiences, and conjectures into a single symbol. After all, the city to which he refers is not a geographic concept but a symbol of modern human life.

One can think of the city as a concentration of multitudes of citizens within more or less precise spatial limits, an ordered distribution of public and private functions within a given territory with its political-social organization; but if we focus on understanding how — out of our desires and fears — we construct group and individual ways of seeing, of inhabiting and un-inhabiting this region called the city, we will be dealing with imaginaries, with things shared, with symbols and stories, which are no less real for that. The urban would correspond to an imaginary effect upon all of this that affects us and conceives us, making us citizens — not of the world, but of a city that inhabits the world.¹² Hence the urban is constituted by the means of communication, the internet, road systems, the sciences, art — in short, technologies.

However much we know that the earth’s surface has not been entirely taken over by human constructions, tales such as Calvino’s continuous cities are in some way a

¹¹CALVINO, Italo. *Cidades invisíveis* [Invisible Cities]. São Paulo: Companhia das Letras, 1991, p. 139.

¹²SILVA, Armando. *Imagários Urbanos*. São Paulo: Perspectiva, 2001.

shared presentiment among the travelers/internet users of the twenty-first century. In any metropolis one finds wide congested avenues; great masses of concrete conjoining several cities; the lack of a homogeneous architectural system or of effective urban regulation (above all in the peripheries); identical multinational stores, all with products from the same countries. Considering the speed of urban growth in the twentieth century and the changes in symbolic production and circulation (always recalling the clear example of new technologies and the reorganizations they imply), it seems that the ensemble of works and messages that once structured visual culture and gave cohesion to a city or locality has lost its efficacy.¹³

To each civilization corresponds its own notion of space.¹⁴ Hence the way a man perceives the space and time in which he lives would depend on the worldview of his cultural context, on shared ideas about how such perception occurs — and, recalling Jonathan Crary's research, it would also depend on the technological apparatuses which, initially shaped by such ideas of perception, equally contribute to transforming them. And to speak of the city also includes speaking of the way we occupy and see sensible space, in order to form from it a kind of imaginary spatial unity. But how to think such space at a moment when distances are shortened by the speed of transport and by the means of communication?

"The city in the age of its touristic reproducibility," another twenty-first-century thinker, Boris Groys,¹⁵ would say, paraphrasing Benjamin, when suggesting that we are post-romantic tourists, at a moment when everyone can travel and the city itself travels — cultural differences come to reproduce and expand on a world scale. Inter-urban differences become intra-urban. A global international metropolis in place of a global village? According to Groys, this is a moment of depoliticization: instead of vanguardism we see nomadism. Universalism would no longer be attempted; cultural forms would expand coherently across the globe even while carrying a local characteristic. "Thus arises, by virtue of total tourism, a homogeneity without universality" — a genuinely contemporary phenomenon.

But what coherence is this? Would such forms not end up adapting, becoming hybrid as they are translated in their journeys across the globe? For Armando Silva, in his study of the construction of imaginaries in different metropolises, what differentiates cities is not so much their architectural capacity — above all after unifying modernism — but the symbols their inhabitants construct to represent them.¹⁶ Even so, we easily

¹³CANCLINI, Néstor García. *Culturas híbridas*. São Paulo: Edusp, 2011.

¹⁴FRANCASTEL, Pierre. *A realidade figurativa*. São Paulo: Perspectiva, 1973.

¹⁵GROYS, Boris. In *Cidades: 25ª Bienal de São Paulo: iconografias metropolitanas*, March 23 - June 2, 2002, Pavilhão Ciccillo Matarazzo, Parque Ibirapuera.

¹⁶SILVA, Armando, op. cit. exhibitions on the theme in relevant institutions, or through newspaper articles, fashion work, and governmental urban planning projects.[^17] Yet what I call urban art in this work is not the only possible way of working artistically with the context of the city. Nor is the city the only and strongest symbol of modern human life. One can say, however, that it is a concept in focus, precisely because we have entered a phase in which more than 50% of humanity inhabits cities,

reach an impasse when thinking about the shared crisis of the modern city: the idea that it can become a consumer product, as in the case of tourism, or that the streets would be little more than places of passage, places of buying and selling.

Néstor García Canclini argues that a nation today would hardly define itself through its territorial limits or its political history: a more adequate notion would be to see it as an interpretive community of consumers. In defining consumption as the set of sociocultural processes in which the appropriation and uses of products take place, Canclini shows how this activity is part of the structures that think and organize what we desire, having become a process in which desires turn into socially regulated demands and acts. It would be traditional habits — alimentary, linguistic, and so on — that lead a society to relate in a particular way to the objects and information circulating in international networks. Yet at the same time there would be international communities of consumers in which a feeling of belonging dilutes national loyalties. After all, several decades of construction of transnational symbols would have created a kind of international popular culture, with a collective memory made of fragments of different nations, with signs of constant availability. Radio and television, for example, by putting diverse ethnic and regional historical heritages into relation and diffusing them massively, would function as coordinators of the multiple temporalities of different spectators.

If radio and television already had such an effect, would it not be strengthened, or unfolded, as millions of observers adhere to the digital world? Above all at a moment when every street is methodically becoming visible in its details through the eyes of Google Maps. How to participate, how to intervene in the city? In what ways has one sought to re-signify the space of a street — remembering that we speak of an observer who, besides being spectator and reader, is simultaneously an internet user?

Growing attention has been paid to urban interventions, above all those carried out informally, as ways of artistically expressing the experience of life in a city. This attention can be seen within the art world, with the organization of

Recalling Armando Silva's concept of the urban, or that of Giulio Carlo Argan — according to which the urban is also constituted by gestures, dress, technologies, and artistic productions, even when these take a landscape as their theme — the designation "urban art" may seem excessively flawed. Is art not a largely urban phenomenon? The use of this expression, urban art, is due precisely to the breadth of productions it can encompass, with the restriction that they be manifestations with artistic intention for which the city constitutes not only their theme or context but also their support. We could think of some specificities of such productions: they have the city as support and as a constituent of the intervention's meaning — their interactions with passersby

a proportion that keeps growing — "The world has entered the urban millennium" were the words used by Kofi Annan, former Secretary-General of the United Nations, at the inauguration of HABITAT II, the Second Global Conference on Human Settlements, held in 2001.[¹⁸]

do not take place in an environment conditioned for their enjoyment or preservation, and for this reason these observers can often choose to intervene in the works if they really want to — and, if made informally, that is, illegally, these works can reach a great number of passersby without having passed through the censorship and bureaucracy that usually mediate between artists and spectators.

At least, these could be the characteristics shared by most works of urban art; but works like Blu's videos make clear that such definitions are not always applicable. Working with the city as support and signifier encompasses countless possibilities to be explored, especially at a moment when our perception of space is shaped by instruments that coordinate different temporalities and localities, like the internet, which constantly appears with some new device. Moreover, if in Groy's words the city itself travels, these artists who produce works for public space are constantly traveling and occupying other cities, just as their works can travel independently of them, being reproduced in other corners — as Shepard Fairey showed so well.

Nevertheless, as I intend to show by the end of the chapter, if certain artists are recognized as urban artists even when they do not limit themselves to producing works intrinsically linked to the city, and if there is an idea of a kind of urban art movement often called graffiti or street art, this is due in large part to the virtual communities that group and frame such productions.

In 1979 Jean Baudrillard wrote that graffiti writing, like the wave of works with ethical-political content (paintings or posters) made by collectives of young people, was born right after the repression of the great urban uprisings of 1966–1970. But unlike those ideologized expressions, Baudrillard praises New York graffiti as an authentic insurrection by signs, a counterposition of the pseudonym to anonymity, achieving subversion precisely by not trying to revalue the subject lost in the crowd or to formulate ideas of depth at the level of political signifieds, but by acting on the signifiers, leaving them empty. "A savage offensive like the demonstrations, but of another type, one that changed content and terrain. A new type of intervention in the city — no longer as a place of economic and political power, but as the space/time of the terrorist power of the media, of signs, and of dominant culture."¹⁷ The graffiti he describes would have flourished with violence in New York in 1972; it was specific to that metropolitan region; its pioneers were young Black and Puerto Rican people, their pseudonyms drawn from underground comics; and it was already coming to an end as he wrote those observations.

Another significant reference for the history of the so-called graffiti movement, Cedar Lewisohn's book *Street Art: The Graffiti Revolution*,¹⁸ published in 2006, says that

¹⁷BAUDRILLARD, Jean. "Kool Killer, or the Insurrection by Signs," translated [into Portuguese] by Fernando Mesquita. *Revista Cinema/Cine Olho*, n. 5, Jul/Aug 1979.

¹⁸LEWISOHN, Cedar. *Street Art: The Graffiti Revolution*. London: Tate Gallery, 2008.

graffiti as known today began as an attempt by marginalized groups in New York City in the mid-1970s to break out of the individual anonymity that suffocated them — especially living in a city where glamour and famous personalities are so present, but which was going through a tense phase of debt and deteriorating public services — an idea of identity-claiming that Baudrillard rejected. And precisely in this pursuit of fame and recognition within their community of street painters, having a more beautiful and striking mark became an essential requirement, so that inventiveness, competition, and aesthetic force quickly became important parts of the movement that would spread through the world in the 1980s, carried along with hip-hop and the magazines and books on the subject.

Apart from the many disagreements about dates, exact places, motives, and the ethnic groups involved, when the rise of graffiti or street painting at the end of the twentieth century is recounted, most histories keep the same focus on the New York of the 1970s. This narrative errs, however, in giving the impression that there existed one concise movement called graffiti, or that it had a well-defined beginning before becoming a worldwide tendency following the same lines as its pioneers. A series of local histories mix together in the creation of this idea of a supposed worldwide movement that would propel so many people to take up their colored paints in the street under that name. However much Lewisohn, like some others, refers to Renaissance frescoes, Mexican muralism, or Brassai's photographs as precedents of graffiti — being impulses of popular groups to occupy the street — his narrative suggests that it was in the New York of the late 1970s that this form of occupation became a movement, in the sense of sharing a philosophy, a language, and goals.



Fig. 5 — 1972, Jon Naar. Photograph published in the book “The Faith of Graffiti,” New York.

How much do those young Americans of the 1970s not owe their fame, and the continuity of their activity, to those who took such interest in their marks as to make them the subject of books and magazines? As early as 1974 the book *The Faith of Graffiti* was published, with photographs from 1972–73 by the photographer Jon Naar and an introductory text by Norman Mailer, the influential American journalist who twice won the Pulitzer Prize¹⁹ and was already writing for the Times when the book came out. Mailer presents the inscriptions of names on the surfaces of New York public places as cultural expressions worthy of artistic value, comparing them at more than one moment with great names of Western art history, even while affirming differences in the degree of the graffiti writers' artistic relevance. This book seems to have been the first to grant such artistic significance to popular inscriptions on the surfaces of public establishments — even though, since the 1930s, Brassai had been making attentive photographic series of popular paintings and inscriptions on the peripheries of Paris, first published in 1934 in the surrealist magazine *Minotaure*, influential among the intellectuals of the period. The images captured by Brassai have been cited by Lewisohn and others as a distant precedent of graffiti; but in rethinking how the expansion of New York street painting came about, perhaps an example of an already delineated tendency — of photographers and the intellectual elite paying attention and granting artistic value to popular expressions in public space — matters more than a mere disconnected predecessor. Would this favorable attention focused on the first graffiti writers not have been one of the drivers of their aesthetic development, or at least of their self-recognition as an artistic activity, given that the wall writers themselves did not yet attribute such value to their writing?



Fig. 6 — 1972, Jon Naar. Photograph contained in the book *“The Faith of Graffiti,”* New York.

¹⁹Wikipedia — http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Norman_Mailer, accessed June 2012.

Another peculiar characteristic of the graffiti writing of the 1970s in relation to the many that preceded it, at least in New York, would be the use of spray paint, which marked its language and facilitated its spread. In a more recent interview, Jon Naar even presents photos of his own, taken in 1959, of what he calls gang graffiti²⁰ — the most striking difference between these and the images of the early 70s is the quantity of inscriptions the later photos show condensed in the same spaces. The use of spray paint in this street writing — which some say began to gain importance in the Paris of '68²¹ — along with its sheer quantity, the fact that the inscriptions no longer referred to anything beyond themselves, and the recognition of distinct calligraphic styles in each region of the city, seem to have been the characteristics that most caught Mailer's attention at the time.

In 1984 *Subway Art* was published, with photographs by Martha Cooper and Henry Chalfant — another book considered an icon of graffiti's visibility and acceptance. The images presented there show a more sophisticated artistic language compared to those of *The Faith of Graffiti*: varied use of color in the composition of letters, more individualized calligraphic styles, as well as intensive use of characters, most of them drawn from the creative industry (Donald Duck, Scooby-Doo, cartoons and comics). New York graffiti was already something else; it had developed its categories (tags, throw-ups, bombs, pieces) and hierarchies (kings were its leaders, and crowns designated that title). But one could no longer say that graffiti was solely a New York or American affair. In England it was already flourishing; in Brazil, *pichação* (the name given to the inscription of names on walls in that Latin American country) and street stencils were already proliferating; artists like Keith Haring and Jean-Michel Basquiat were exhibiting their work internationally and being recognized as graffiti, even though both had little to do, formally and conceptually, with the better-known train graffiti.²²

²⁰http://fora.tv/2007/10/11/Jon_Naar_Birth_Of_Graffiti. Accessed May 2012.

²¹GITAHY, Celso. *O que é graffiti?* [What Is Graffiti?]. São Paulo: Brasiliense, 1999.

²²In an interview, Futura 2000 — one of the few New York graffiti writers who began in the 70s and to this day sells his work and is recognized — said that Keith and Jean had very different backgrounds from the other train graffiti writers: one had a degree in art, the other was a great reader interested in diverse cultural expressions. In *Beyond the Street*; see bibliography.



Fig. 7 — 1981, Martha Cooper. Photograph published in the book “Subway Art,” New York.



Fig. 8 — 1980, Martha Cooper. Photograph published in the book “Subway Art,” New York.

A story that usually goes untold when recounting the popularization of spray painting in urban space is that of Alex Vallauri, a Brazilian artist with strong ties to pop art, who in 1985 exhibited works elaborated on the graffiti aesthetic at the São Paulo Biennial — the edition following the one in which Keith Haring participated. Vallauri was already known for spreading stencils of little boots and other images through the city of São Paulo, having begun in 1977 according to his companions. In 1979 other groups began making inscriptions around the city that oscillated between poetry and conceptual art, such as Tadeu Jungle and the group 3NÓS3; but Haring’s presence helped disseminate freehand painting done illegally throughout the city.²³ Other young adolescents of

²³ CARVALHO, Mario Cesar. *Keith Haring, ah se a gente não precisasse dormir*. São Paulo: Cosac Naify, 2010.

that city began painting in the street in the 1980s influenced by hip-hop, and so they adopted and adapted the name — *grafite* — but the material on foreign graffiti to which they had access was scarce, and one might say they were equally influenced by skate culture and Japanese comics.

If the most common narrative today, when speaking of graffiti, always refers back to the New Yorkers who wrote their pseudonyms on trains, this is because the idea of a movement called graffiti — an expression which until then designated any illegal inscription in a public space — was attributed at that moment, and because other narratives institutionalized that history as the original one. In the same way, the practice of painting and writing in the street in other localities came to be recognized as a continuation of what flourished in NY, and new artists adopted the name. But the histories are many — as one unfolds into another, why would we say that one is the original? When the name graffiti arrived in these places — through magazines, books, news, and on a smaller scale along with traveling American or European graffiti writers — even though it strongly influenced the locals with its already codified language (terms like tags, king, bombs, pieces, crews were incorporated), it was translated and modified, keeping the name and some references but becoming something else.

Speaking of graffiti matters when one wishes to reflect on the production of urban art at the end of the twentieth century and the beginning of the twenty-first, because the shadow of this idea of a movement permeates the work of a good part of those who began intervening artistically in public space in the last two decades, especially those who paint walls or act illegally. One could say that the diffusion of the name graffiti and the visual languages associated with it, together with the prestige it gained within the art world itself in the 1980s, were responsible for popularizing the practice of street painting to an unprecedented extent. Although particular histories of street painting already existed in various localities, when the idea of graffiti exploded along with hip-hop culture in the transition from the 70s to the 80s, a great number of people — young people above all — who had not the slightest contact with the fine arts began to paint every available public wall within their reach, many of them attentive to the aesthetic dimension of their practice.

Having to take a position on the countless inscriptions and drawings made with spray cans or latex paint is a relevant question for most urban agglomerations today. More recently, with the repercussion that so-called street art has been gaining, one could again see an illusion of a cohesive artistic movement taking shape — above all because there exists a kind of virtual community, organized around a few reference websites, that eagerly shares images of the most recent street works every day.

But other narratives have been spreading that do not focus on defining the names of movements — it would rather be a social phenomenon — and that think the recent history of urban art more broadly. The book *Trespass: A History of Uncommissioned Urban Art*, by Marc and Sara Schiller, editors of the Wooster Collective site, together

with Carlo McCormick, and with an introduction by Banksy, could be seen as a reference for telling a less linear and more plural history of this artistic interest in the streets over the last four decades — together with Lewisohn's book, which also gives great importance to artists of the 1970s outside the realm titled graffiti. What matters is no longer to speak of graffiti or to delimit another idea of a movement, but to present different impulses of unauthorized occupation of the street through works made by more than one generation. *Trespass* presents itself as an apology for the transgression of social norms as acts of freedom capable of potentiating artistic expression and social critique. In interviews, Marc and Sara stress the view that these artists would have the freedom to produce works that play with the city, taking advantage of the elements of the urban context to produce unexpected meanings. The number of artists from the 70s and 80s present in the book is striking: Gordon Matta-Clark, whose work *Blowout* is also the cover image; Christy Rupp's rats; Alex Grey's *Private Subway*; Jenny Holzer's texts scattered through cities; Vito Acconci's performances. After all, if we think about the richness of art production in the 60s and 70s, we see how the limits of art's production and exhibition were already being questioned by various groups — how artists were already trying to escape the framing of the white cube, in an era when speculation was gaining force over the price of artworks, treated as investments in cultural goods.²⁴

Lewisohn is a figure of importance for the current urban art scene as an English artist who works for the Tate Gallery and curated the exhibition "Street Art," which proclaims itself the first dedicated to this type of work in an institution of major relevance. But Sara and Marc Schiller are even stronger references because of the power their site, the Wooster Collective, holds for the dissemination of urban art and for connecting the various groups that produce it. Founded in 2001, the site calls itself a celebration of ephemeral art made in the streets; over recent years its editors have published thousands of photographs and videos of works made in hundreds of cities around the world, as well as interviews they themselves conducted with artists who caught their attention; they also organize events and exhibitions, such as the "11 Spring Project," held in an abandoned building in New York in 2006. In the early years, Marc and Sara had to seek out the interventions happening in their city and on the international scene, but they later achieved such popularity that they now have to select what to publish from among the hundreds of e-mails they receive daily with images of works. The audience that visits Wooster is also quite varied, even if its editors recognize that there is a group of internet users who follow it and seek out the other sites on the same theme, constituting a virtual community of urban art observers.

The Wooster editors write in *Trespass* that technology played a crucial role in the rapid

²⁴HOBBSAWM, Eric. *The Age of Extremes: The Short Twentieth Century*. São Paulo: Companhia das Letras, 1995. of the most recent generation of urban artists, which matured during the rise of the internet, a strong feeling of community — the fruit of this contact with others through the web — would characterize the group.

development of unauthorized practices of public art. The affordable digital camera, for example, made it possible to document and share any work, just as the internet allowed artists to see works from the whole world in one night in front of the computer. In the exchange of stories, critiques, and techniques, a strong community developed — a community that drives these artists' experimentation and refinement. If these are questions common to any working group today, for Marc and Sara, in the case

Or as these authors argue in interviews: "Street art is truly the first global art movement fueled by the internet (...). The rise in popularity and acceptance of street art is directly connected with the rise of the internet."²⁵ Even if calling it a "global art movement" is questionable, the Wooster statement seems pertinent, and it shows a process of legitimation and popularization of recent street art practices very different from those experienced, for example, by what was called the graffiti movement in the 1970s.

The first website about urban art dates from 1994; it is called artcrimes.com and is devoted specifically to graffiti (it also has the web address graffiti.org). Its purpose was to record the history of graffiti through photos, magazines, and academic works, becoming a great database on the subject while also seeking to publicize the practice and its artists — by 2004 it had published works made in more than 445 cities around the world. It urges graffiti writers (though it also publicizes practices beyond graffiti writing) to preserve their history by making it digital, available to the site's 50,000 daily visits.

Since then many other sites have gained importance, such as Fecalface.com, launched in 2000 by John Trippe in San Francisco (USA), which since 2008 has also functioned as a gallery. Working with the categories street art, painting, photography, collage, illustration, design, and graffiti, the site conducts interviews and publicizes artists' work, besides publishing articles on varied themes. Trippe began by publishing a small-distribution magazine, then launched his site and gradually gained importance as a reference for San Francisco underground culture, later internationally, publicizing the work of several artists who thereby gained recognition vis-à-vis the institutionalized fine arts scene. About creating the gallery, John explains: "I always wanted a gallery space to show art I liked. Seeing art online is one thing; in person it is another experience. I have seen works online that I thought were great until I saw them in person. Conversely, I have seen wonderful works in person that were not the same online."²⁶

A similar story is that of the site 12ozprophet.com, which also began as a magazine — but one of wide distribution — and was the first to publish an international interview

²⁵SCHILLER, Marc and Sara. In *Beyond the Streets...* "Street art is truly the first global art movement fuelled by the internet. (...) The rise in popularity and acceptance of street art are directly connected with the rise of the internet" (author's free translation).

²⁶Interview with Soma. <http://soma.am/noticia/quem-soma-john-trippe>. Accessed May 2012.

with Osgemeos, back in the 1990s. Since 2002 it has been a website, the largest forum on the theme on the internet, hosting blogs by figures such as Nunca, Osgemeos, and Martha Cooper. For a good part of art production in public space, these sites were its showcase and its connector long before sponsored urban art festivals began to proliferate (such as MOF in Rio de Janeiro, Nuart in Norway, FAME in Italy, etc.) and before the doors of the great art institutions were opened to it. Few artists from the illegal urban art scene had achieved recognition in sales and prices before the 2000s; after all, the graffiti boom of the 1980s itself was short-lived, as the artist Futura 2000 recounts.²⁷ These artists today produce their work already aware of this great international community of spectators who will judge their works through photos and videos.

These are works produced in public spaces by artists who have defined origins but who travel the whole world painting, and whose work images are simultaneously absorbed worldwide through the web — or rather, they are works made to appear on the web, since they are ephemeral at their place of origin and are conceived so as to create interesting narratives with their surroundings when photographically framed. Often the meanings of the work, or its joke, are clearer in the photo than for a passerby who stumbles upon the work without an introduction to it. Some, like Alexandre Orion of São Paulo, have this focus declaredly, and one can recognize it easily in his series *Metabiotics*, which is sold in galleries both as large framed photographic reproductions and as small boxes with a series of photos — all showing a specific interaction of wall paintings with passersby.

Even so, few acknowledge the extent to which photographic framing matters for the production of these works. Marc and Sara Schiller of Wooster stress the importance of the internet for the expansion of what they call street art, achieving a worldwide community connected through the sharing of blogs, forums, and so on, organizing events primarily through the internet. But even they — editors of one of the reference sites for viewing works made in urban space, who select the photos to be published and compose books on urban art — defend the presence of the work as still irreplaceable: the encounter with works in the street would be what is essential, and their digital counterpart would matter more as publicity and as a place of discussion.

We would not argue here that the presence of a good work is simply replaceable by its image on a computer screen or in print; but could we say that all these works have their primary enjoyment in the street encounter? With the familiarity we have with the infinite reproduction of images, in this wave of virtualization we are living through, would there not be works whose unfolding and enjoyment occur precisely in the form of websites, books, photos, or videos? Or even works that operate upon a vision that presupposes photographic framing?

One could think of the coordination of temporalities and of the image-perception of ob-

²⁷Interview published in the book *Beyond the Street*; see bibliography.

servers in distinct spaces — performed by mechanisms like television and the internet — as part of a general movement of virtualization. Countering catastrophic hypotheses about the cultural evolutions underway, an author like Pierre Lévy tries to show them as part of an expression of the pursuit of hominization.²⁸ This French thinker presents virtualization as the inverse movement of actualization, in the sense that the former is a problematic complex while the latter appears as a solution — the invention of a form out of a dynamic configuration of forces and ends. The virtual is generally not present, but that does not mean it ceases to exist. For example, a company that stops operating in a determinate physical space in order to base itself on its employees' communication via the internet would have undergone a virtualization; but it continues to actualize itself in each small meeting, each solution it creates for this new mode of functioning. For Lévy, although we are at an accentuated moment of virtualization, this process is the movement by which our species constituted itself and continues to create itself — so that the very creation of writing and of symbols, as signs that represent or substitute for another thing/presence, would be virtualizations. On this point the Frenchman closely resembles Flusser, who narrates humanity's tendency toward abstraction as it passed from communication based on two-dimensionality to one-dimensionality and then zero-dimensionality.

Would this loss of aura — or the de-centering of a work's meaning from its presence — not be part of this process of virtualization that human perception is undergoing? Perhaps one can say this is an old and long process; but with the accelerated twentieth- and now twenty-first-century development of new apparatuses and ideas that enable and shape vision, or the modes of perceiving, this tendency toward virtualization becomes sharper — at least according to authors like Lévy. Or we may think of the formulations of Reinhart Koselleck, for whom, since the modern era, the difference between the horizon of expectation and the space of experience has progressively increased; hence the fact that this questioning of the process of virtualization becomes more evident may be taken as a fruit of the acceleration of historical time, linked to the modern idea of progress.²⁹

These possibilities of enjoying works made specifically for a given space through images that no longer depend on their physical presence would not be very different from Walter Benjamin's interest in cinema as an art based on technical reproducibility, in which the idea of an original piece/film is no longer so relevant.³⁰ The contact of a contemporary observer carrying a smartphone, for example, with a work of art — or with images in general — would already always be mediated by the possibility of transforming anything at any moment into a photograph or video, and even of sharing them simultaneously on a virtual social network. What this means for that observer's

²⁸LÉVY, Pierre. *O que é o virtual?* [What Is the Virtual?]. São Paulo: Editora 34, 2011.

²⁹KOSELLECK, Reinhart. *Futures Past: On the Semantics of Historical Time*. Rio de Janeiro: Contraponto, 2006.

³⁰BENJAMIN, Walter. "The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technical Reproducibility." São Paulo: Abril, 1983.

production of meanings and of new images is one of the questions to be reflected upon through the works described and analyzed in this text.

Chapter 3 — Superstar Artist

If modern metropolises share so many of the same problems of organization and other particulars, London stands out as one of the most surveilled cities in the world. At least as regards ground-level cameras, or CCTV (closed-circuit television), the English capital has the largest number of surveillance cameras per capita in the world. Paul Lewis's article, published in the London newspaper *The Guardian* in 2009,³¹ described how London was a pioneer in high-tech police security, becoming a model that aroused the curiosity of public authorities responsible for the security of cities like São Paulo, Baltimore, and Beijing. Lewis emphasizes at the end of his text that this system is still under intense debate, since there is evidence that 80% of the camera images are of such poor quality that they could not be used to detect a crime, and it had been estimated that only 3% of crimes were solved with the help of the CCTV system. Why would London need so many cameras? The English public authorities maintain that the system is essential to prevent possible terrorist attacks; for others it is a sign of the paranoia of English society — or, in Lewis's words, a high-tech version of what the eighteenth-century English philosopher Jeremy Bentham conceived as the "Panopticon": a space where people can be constantly monitored without ever knowing they are being observed.

In this permanently surveilled city, where painting without formal authorization in public space is considered a crime, whoever decides to paint with spray cans is subject to a fine of at least 80 pounds if caught in the act, in addition to possible imprisonment for three months plus community service.³² It was on one of the traditional streets of the English capital, Portobello Road, right in the historic center packed with cameras and police, that Banksy carried out the intervention already mentioned in chapter 1, in broad daylight, under the disguise of the scaffolding. In figure 9 below one can even see the shadow of a camera over the work — though I could not say whether it was installed before or after the painting; possibly after, for what else would it surveil from such an angle? This work displays a kitsch notion of how a traditional painter ought to look, in the caricatured dress of an old academic artist, executed in black-and-white stencil technique. The figure's pose suggests he is in the process of giving the final brushstroke to his newest work of art — a work that is a graffiti bomb.³³ Made at pedestrian level, at approximately human scale, it is a joke about the painter's craft and his pose of importance — while it can also be read as a suggestion that the bomb, or the name/brand Banksy, is worthy of being admired like a painting. The irony unfolds precisely in the fact that the English public authorities spend thousands of pounds per month cleaning this type of name inscription off the streets; yet because

³¹LEWIS, Paul. In <http://www.guardian.co.uk/uk/2009/mar/02/westminster-cctv-system-privacy>. Accessed May 2012.

³²English legislation: Anti-social Behaviour Act 2003. <http://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/2003/38/contents>

³³In Brazil we call a "bomb" the writing of a name in that rapid calligraphy, yet more worked and voluminous than a tag.

it was made by a well-known artist, the work was not only recognized as art but protected and sold. In the city of London, as shown by the article in the magazine *Beaux Arts* of October 2010 and the documentary “Graffiti Wars” made for Britain’s Channel 4 in 2011, cleaning staff of companies such as Network Rail, responsible for the city’s trains, are actually trained not to erase street works by known artists, since these are tourist attractions and their monetary value is recognized. Even though, according to the law, this type of unauthorized work is simply a criminal offense.



Fig. 9 — 2008, Banksy, spray paint on wall, approx. 2.5 m × 1.80 m, London — current location undisclosed.

In its technical aspects, Banksy’s stencil is not simple either: the coverage of the black spray in the dark areas is not uniform, providing effects of light and shadow and highlighting areas of the image through strong contrasts. In some places, as in the passage from the suit to the white shirt, the artist seems to have used spectrum black spray, a more transparent color specifically for making light shadows. The reading of the forms proceeds through the alternation between black outlines and areas where mere patches of color with different values induce the difference of planes. Even the outlines are not standard: they are thin, discontinuous dark lines that lend more refinement to the drawing, as can be seen at the borders with the light background, on the face, the suit, or the palette. Even the dripping of the bomb’s drawing is ambiguous: it gives the impression that it has just been painted, or that the drip signifies a more expressive brushstroke by the artist — yet for most wall writers paint drips were usually perceived as an error, dirty work done without mastery of the spray can — which would make the painter’s posture all the more comical. The palette held by the character likewise seems a joke, since it mixes only the same standard red

paint, with no need to separate it into tones, as he does. The painter's craft appears equally laughable if we consider the box that assists him with various materials — apparently containers of oil-paint solvent, which would obviously be useless for the kind of industrial paint used in graffiti name writing. Not content with that, the painter carries yet another brush in his hand, as if he were doing sophisticated work of many chromatic variations. Looking at the painting's surroundings, one may even think the painted bomb matches the red of the window beside it.

The illegality of his practice is a constituent, an essential part, of the meaning of this artist's work — in a way quite different from the graffiti writers who write, above all, their pseudonyms. If illegality was once important for gaining fame as someone who made satirical paintings in unexpected places, now the very illegality of urban manifestations and their histories is his theme. Banksy used to be recognized for his use of diverse supports — the street, or paintings, prints, and sculptures, always making an installation with a similar joke — but in recent years his work has diversified between works with robots and the production of documentaries, both for cinema and for TV. Yet even as his means diversify, he continues to be considered an icon of graffiti or street art culture — always remembering how confused and encompassing these definitions are, and how, with the works of artists like this anonymous Englishman, they end up stretching even further to embrace new productions. After all, in his few writings in his book, or in the e-mail interviews of recent years, Banksy always presents himself as a graffiti writer. For Cedar Lewisohn, he is the best-known street artist working today, and even though he has a graffiti background, his works would fit more in the street art model. Graffiti or not graffiti, owing to the high values reached by sales of his works and the attraction of the news media around his name, Banksy is seen as one of the drivers of a phenomenon of visibility granted to the most recent artistic productions in the urban scene. A phenomenon called, by the Wooster Collective³⁴ and by CNN journalist Max Foster,³⁵ since the end of 2006, the "Banksy Effect."

Marc and Sara Schiller offer as evidence of this effect the fact that *Wall and Piece*, the book "authored" by Banksy and published in 2005, is available — with significant sales — in an enormous number of bookstores, from megastores to the most alternative ones, in addition to his work selling for hundreds of thousands of dollars at Sotheby's auctions. They say the success Banksy obtained in the sale and publicizing of his works opened doors for other artists working in the same field of urban interventions. The CNN report (December 22, 2006), in turn, uses Banksy's print directly inspired by Andy Warhol's work as an example of his boom in visibility: when released in 2005, the print of the actress Kate Moss represented as if she were one of Warhol's Marilyns sold for 3,000 dollars; in October 2006 a print from that series was priced at 17,000; in

³⁴http://www.woostercollective.com/2007/02/the_banksy_effect.html — accessed April 2012.

³⁵<http://www.esnips.com/doc/b4c1d2fc-5e85-4610-a094-21f915883fb2/the-banksy-effect-Dec-22> — accessed April 2012.

December of the same year an art dealer sold another for 60,000.³⁶ At least, this is how the artist's importance for the acceptance and visibility of urban artworks is presented from the perspective of the great international art markets, especially auctions. Yet if we consider the career trajectory of artists like OsGemeos, who have gradually increased their recognition since the 1990s and also had a leap in visibility in 2005 — the year of their first exhibition at the Deitch Projects gallery in New York³⁷ — it becomes necessary to relativize the importance of a single artist. In any case, Banksy initially became known for stencils made in Bristol, works largely concerned with recurring questions for those who live the day-to-day of an urban center. These are made predominantly in black, at times with a few other colors, with a technique that probably also involves a computer, given the photocopy-like character of the drawing in some of his images. These works — and he continues to produce new ones — clearly expose an aversion to the concepts of authority and power, making social as well as behavioral and political critiques of a society the artist accuses, in his internet statements, of being excessively paranoid and oppressive. Yet even while frequently aggressive in his approach — above all when he makes a critique so explicit that it borders on, or indeed becomes, simplistic — Banksy seems to believe in the theory of the subversive power of laughter, always resorting to good jokes or to the ridiculous, mindful of what is laughable in the most radical groups of social critique, or even in his own position as a no-longer-underground artist. Rats, cameras, soldiers, and children appear frequently in his repertoire of stencils, which is considerably figurative, though since the early 2000s he had already presented works consisting solely of words or loose phrases, or even poems, satirizing the surroundings where they are placed.

The French magazine *Beaux-Arts*, on the occasion of the release of Banksy's film in France, produced a special supplement on his work, which included an interview with the film's French distributor and a short account of how Banksy's rise to fame unfolded. In the account of the journalist responsible for the supplement, Thomas Jean, one of the few certainties

His exhibitions have grown in size and popularity ever since. In 2006, at the opening of his exhibition "Barely Legal" in a Los Angeles warehouse, Hollywood celebrities attended — Angelina Jolie, for example, spent 200,000 pounds on three of the artist's

³⁶For more recent results: <http://www.banksy-prints.com/2010/02/banksy-auction-christies-sothebys/>

³⁷Only a year later, already with a strong name abroad, OSGEMEOS held their first exhibition in Brazil at Galeria Fortes Vilaça, in São Paulo. Information from www.osgemeos.com.br — accessed May 2012. one would have about Banksy is his date of birth: 1974, in Bristol. The journalist goes on to narrate how Banksy began with a common style in the early 1990s, in a Bristol already occupied by letter graffiti, starting his street marks with colorful hand-drawn graffiti writing and gaining prominence when he moved to a more sober style with the stencil technique. In 1998, during the graffiti festival called "Walls on Fire," the artist drew much attention, and the following year, with the mural "Mild Mild West," he became one of the best-known graffiti or street artists in England — even without any record of his appearing in public. In the meantime Banksy had also invested in producing paintings and experimenting with photographs, presenting his first solo show at the Severnshed restaurant in his hometown in 2000. It was a triumph: all the works were sold, and the English media began paying attention to this "anonymous artist oscillating between hype and clandestinity." [^40]

works.³⁸ If the artistic taste of film celebrities does not usually carry weight as critical judgment in the art world, in this case it certainly raised his prices and popularity, an event frequently cited as proof of his value. In any case, still according to Thomas's article, when Damien Hirst publicly declared himself a Banksy fan in 2006, being a collector of his works, the "Banksy Effect" came to be taken more seriously — reinforced when Damien and Banksy created a joint work, "Keep It Spotless," whose sale in 2008 reached nearly 1.9 million dollars at Sotheby's New York.

"Keep It Spotless" is a painting featuring the colored dots typical of Damien Hirst's canvases — dots of equal size, each a different color, spaced from one another at the distance of another dot — with a Banksy stencil on top, showing a luxury maid sweeping dirt toward the brick wall that would lie behind the canvas. Hirst's dot paintings gain more force if we consider that each is part of a whole that extends indefinitely, in any direction and dimension, as if it were an alternative reality of colored atoms, each different from the next, arranged in a strongly rational and standardized way — so regular they hardly seem paintings made by the hands of his assistants.³⁹ Banksy's stencil, in turn, which had previously been produced on a London street, suggests the act of hiding dirt and dust behind the curtain of artworks, revealing the canvas's common structure. If on the street this stencil could signify the covering-up of the problems and inequalities present in public space, in the collaboration with Hirst the most evident interpretation would be a critique of the art market and of the monetary appreciation the canvas itself would provoke — the black-and-white treatment of the maid (who looks forward like someone caught in the act, yet with an expression tending toward indifference) contrasting sharply with the hypnotizing colors of the dots.



³⁸Ibid., JEAN, Thomas. Information also present in online newspapers and forums.

³⁹GOPNIK, Blake. In Newsweek Magazine, January 15, 2012 — found at <http://www.thedailybeast.com/newsweek/2012/01/15/damien-hirst-s-spot-paintings-take-over-the-world.html>, accessed May 2012.

Fig. 10 — 2008, Banksy and Damien Hirst, “Keep It Spotless,” mixed media on canvas, shown at Sotheby’s NY.

Yet Banksy’s standing as one of the most internationally renowned engaged artists is certainly linked to his 2005 project, when he painted the most famous wall in the world. Some of the largest international newspapers, as Thomas Jean recalls, retransmitted the images of his paintings made on the wall separating Palestine from Israel in the Ramallah region — playful paintings suggesting a passage, an opening of a path through the wall. Reports on this event are accessible on YouTube, such as the one by Britain’s Channel 4,⁴⁰ aired on August 5, 2005, which also includes a video — according to the channel, a courtesy of the artist — showing a man with his back turned, in broad daylight, painting the wall with the help of two people, several cars stopped in a traffic jam right in front, and armed soldiers observing the site. The artist and his team are also said to have sent a message to the channel reading: “The segregation wall is a disgrace; the possibility I find exciting is that you could turn the world’s most invasive and degrading structure into the world’s longest gallery of free speech and bad art,”⁴¹ and according to the reporter he also wrote a little about the process and the reactions of passersby.

It is intriguing to imagine that an artist could have carried out such an action without being apprehended by the soldiers and having his identity revealed. After the story was published, several newspapers tried to discover his identity, but since the answers of his then-spokesman were indifferent or negative, the revelations put forward proved to be no more than speculation. Banksy continued his work in the Ramallah area when he returned in 2007 as organizer of Santa’s Ghetto — an annual exhibition of works by artists linked to the urban scene and other alternative groups, held every December since the early 2000s in London — which that year moved its exhibition venue to the city of Bethlehem, occupying an ordinary shop space along with the city’s open areas and the famous separation wall with Israeli territory. The event included thirty artists, some internationally known for their work in public space, such as the Italian Blu, and several others who were local.

Other interventions that gave Banksy visibility beyond the community of those who follow urban art were his installations of fake works in major museums, begun around 2002. He would produce or adapt paintings and objects from different eras — some altered reproductions of famous works, others originals by unknown authors bought in antique shops — and take advantage of security flaws to paste these works on museum walls, with an explanatory label beside them as if they were part of the regular collection; and some of these works really were incorporated into the collections. These interventions, together with his polemical street interventions and

⁴⁰http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=umas99F_z6U — accessed April 2012.

⁴¹In the report’s video one reads: “The segregation wall is a disgrace, the possibility I find exciting is you could turn the world’s most invasive and degrading structure into the world’s longest gallery of free speech and bad art,” with the phrase attributed to Banksy.

his exhibitions — always staged as eye-catching spectacles — were the works that made possible the so-called “Banksy Effect” on the prices of artworks linked to urban art. If many of Banksy’s works are criticized as repetitive and weakly humorous — as Lewisohn recalls when publishing the negative comment of the impresario Malcolm McLaren about the artist⁴² — what most deserves attention for this study is how well-architected this artist’s strategy for achieving recognition is.

“I use art to contest the established order, but perhaps I simply use contestation to promote my works.”⁴³ With this sentence attributed to Banksy, Thomas Jean ends his article on the artist. In some of his most recent productions, it seems to be precisely this ambiguity of the artist toward the art market, or toward consumerism, that is the most potent question behind them.

In January 2010 the documentary *Exit Through the Gift Shop* was presented at the Sundance Festival (located in the state of Utah, the largest independent film festival in the USA), having been one of the festival’s last additions to the program, not even appearing in the film catalogue. A few days before the premiere, satirical stencils appeared in the streets of the festival’s city, recognized as Banksy’s, already attracting media attention. According to the account of Jaimie D’Cruz, the film’s producer, almost immediately after the first screenings a consensus began to emerge both in the mainstream media and in the blogosphere: the film was a hoax. Even though the comments and reactions to the documentary were mainly positive, few seemed willing to believe that the story told was real. Jaimie writes that this was a strange position for those who had followed the production of the feature, since they would never have imagined the public could find so strange a narrative about events that were, according to the producer, true and well documented.⁴⁴ The next screening took place in an improvised but well-equipped cinema, decorated with Banksy works, set up on a London street by the artist’s own team. Then, in the European spring of the same year, the film entered wide distribution, winning several prizes, among them the Oscar nomination. The public’s reaction remained curious: people seemed not to believe the story they were being told — and given an anonymous artist known for irreverence, it could be coherent that the film was a set-up.

This distrust arises especially from the feature’s main character, the Frenchman Thierry Guetta, and his improbable biography. According to the film, Guetta was an eccentric Frenchman living in Los Angeles, profiting from selling poor-quality clothes at abusive prices — a man with the strange habit of filming everything that happened around him, for fear of missing an important moment. His life changes when he decides to film Space Invader, the French urban artist said to be his cousin,

⁴²LEWISOHN, Cedar, op. cit.

⁴³“J’utilise l’art pour contester l’ordre établi, mais peut-être que j’utilise simplement la contestation pour promouvoir mes œuvres” (author’s free translation). JEAN, Thomas, op. cit.

⁴⁴Available at <http://moviecitynews.com/2010/10/the-enter-through-the-gift-shop-diaries-pt-2-of-2> — accessed February 2012.

and he becomes addicted to filming the activities of those who produced artworks illegally in the streets. Over the course of the film we see the transition from someone who documents other people's productions out of mere taste — lying that he would someday make a documentary — to a man who decides to become an urban artist himself, and then a commercialized artist with his enormous solo show in a warehouse, featuring more than 300 works produced with his team of assistants in just a few months. The film would end up narrating not only a bit of the history of certain urban artists — especially Banksy and Shepard Fairey — up to the moment they gain great visibility through the phenomenon called street art, while satirizing the creation and commercialization of an artist.

With frequent, even banalized references to Andy Warhol, Thierry — supposedly self-titled Mr. Brainwash — goes so far as to produce serial prints, calling them originals because he throws paint randomly over them. Not so different from a gift shop, where one buys merchandise as a material souvenir after seeing an entertainment spectacle, Thierry made his exhibition a great party/event and manages to produce artworks in series, making collages and games with well-known images of international pop culture. Warhol's famous treatment of Marilyn Monroe, already used by Banksy in his Kate Moss print, is appropriated by Mr. Brainwash so as to confer the elements of the actress's colored images upon so many other characters of American pop culture and politics — including Andy Warhol himself. All these famous individuals are elevated to the category of image-symbols of status and consumption.



Fig. 11 — 2008, Mr. Brainwash, exhibition “Life Is Beautiful” (from the site <http://www.whorange.net/whorange/2008/06/life-is-beautif.html>). Los Angeles, USA.

The circularity of the script — which makes the art exhibition at the end of the film seem not very different from Thierry's used-clothing enterprise — the improbable stories, such as Thierry being interrogated and released by FBI agents for helping Banksy

in his risky intervention at Disneyland, and even the footage quality of certain scenes supposedly filmed by the amateur French filmmaker, all contribute to the impression that the film is fake. The documentary's own distributor in France, Jean Labadie, in an interview in the magazine *Beaux Arts*,⁴⁵ compares *Exit Through the Gift Shop* to Orson Welles's *F for Fake*, describing both as "films that brilliantly interrogate the border between true and false, fiction and reality."⁴⁶ In an article in the *Los Angeles Times*, the journalist Jason Felch researches Thierry Guetta's life and shows that despite his strange trajectory, it is confirmed by public records as well as by the testimony of former partners and employees. Yet Jason leaves open how sincere the last phase of the Frenchman's life — his transformation into an artist — might be: "'Banksy captured me becoming an artist,' the paint-splattered Guetta said, surrounded by the stacks of art books and pop-culture clutter from which his work is derived — or ripped off, depending on your view. 'In the end, I became his biggest work of art.'"⁴⁷

How can we know what the artist expected as the presumed effect of a film whose narrative, however difficult to simply disprove, seems so implausible? One may think he wanted to leave us in doubt about the film's truthfulness; yet Jaimie D'Cruz's account describes the production process of the feature as if the suspicions were unfounded. In e-mail interviews (which the anonymous English artist began giving more frequently after the film's release), Banksy also maintains that he presented Thierry in the film no differently from what the Frenchman already was — hence the public's estrangement would occur because the truth was stranger than the lie. "Maybe it means art is a bit of a joke," Banksy says near the end of the film.

At the same time, the narrative of *Exit* tells the story of street art in a romanticized way, describing it as "the biggest counter-cultural movement since punk," without dwelling on how the artists it presents as protagonists of this scene are by now all institutionalized. The film presents Steve Lazarides merely as Banksy's former spokesman, without commenting on his importance today as a gallerist representing several of the urban artists in the film (Space Invader, Ron English, and Zevs). Shepard Fairey is one of the most prominent figures in the narrative, and while known for his artistic project "Obey"⁴⁸ and for his contribution to Barack Obama's electoral campaign, this artist

⁴⁵JEAN, Thomas, op. cit.

⁴⁶LABADIE, Jean. "Un de ces films qui interrogent brillamment la frontière entre vrai et faux, fiction et réalité," in JEAN, Thomas, op. cit.

⁴⁷FELCH, Jason. *Los Angeles Times*: <http://articles.latimes.com/2011/feb/22/entertainment/la-et-oscar-exit-20110222>

⁴⁸In the "Obey" project, Shepard Fairey always repeats the same image, based on a character from a TV program, spreading it through high-visibility places in several cities. As he himself explains in the manifesto published on his site (<http://www.obeygiant.com/about>), the image means nothing; it is just a face with the imperative "Obey" written beneath it — but its continuous presence prompts observers to seek meanings for it. He writes that he considers his project a phenomenological experiment, in the line of Heidegger, with the primary aim of reawakening a sense of wonder toward one's environment. Begun in 1989, the project came to be produced in several places by other artists who embraced Shepard's idea, becoming a landmark which, according to the Wooster Collective, was the beginning of the street art movement: "For us... Shepard Fairey created the movement... Banksy created the market" (author's

has also turned his art into a clothing line and other merchandise, besides owning design companies. A direct critique of the commercialization of these actors of so-called street art is made explicit in an episode of the 23rd season of “The Simpsons,” the internationally renowned comic animation — an episode titled “Exit Through the Kwik-E-Mart,” which parallels the story of Banksy’s film and in which Shepard Fairey, Kenny Scharf, Ron English, and Robbie Conal contribute as characters and real voices — with Shepard revealing himself to be a government agent whose goal was to arrest graffiti writers. The irony is even stronger if we remember that in the same season, Banksy made the opening of another episode, revealing a sinister Asian factory where children and fantastic animals are exploited to make Simpsons-inspired merchandise.⁴⁹

Banksy’s presentation of himself is quite curious: he remains anonymous and ambiguous in his statements; there is always difficulty in confirming the authenticity of this artist’s works and phrases, which facilitates the proliferation of rumors and fake websites about him; even his own central site (www.banksy.co.uk, where he continually changes photos and texts, using it as a platform for communicating with the public and not merely as a portfolio) presents only a limited portion of his work, without links to his other official sites (such as the one for his film, or for the fake pet shop exhibited in New York), to exhibitions and projects, or to the virtual instrument that certifies his works, called Pest Control. He is nonetheless an artist very careful with his representation, having had an official spokesman since the early 2000s, Steve Lazarides, and now being represented by the public relations professional Jo Brooks. The internet is the instrument through which most of this artist’s public communication and the authentication of his art are carried out — but it seems this process is conducted in a way that heightens the mystery and myth around this artist-character.

Benjamin Liu, a former assistant at Andy Warhol’s Factory, stated in an interview for the book *Warhol TV*: “The question is not whether his films were art. Warhol is art.”⁵⁰ Considering the controversies and mysteries always involved in Banksy’s work, would it not be plausible to say that the character/idea of the mythic urban artist — or brand — is the greatest artwork of whoever stands behind that anonymity? On one of the last pages of his book *Wall and Piece* there is a curious image about his anonymity: a photograph of a young man appearing full-length before a non-uniform wall, holding a canvas that hides his shoulders and head,

free translation) — <http://www.woostercollective.com/post/the-banksy-effect>

⁴⁹The data can easily be confirmed at <http://www.snpp.com/episodeguide/season23.html> — accessed May 2012.

⁵⁰BENHAMOU-HUET, Judith (org.). *Warhol TV*. Rio de Janeiro: Aeroplano, 2011. yet in this canvas the representation continues the man’s body — and still one cannot see his face, for it is censored with large pixels.



Fig. 12 — 2005, Banksy. Photograph published in “Wall and Piece” — see bibliography.

Andy Warhol’s connection with urban art, and with graffiti itself, dates back to the 1970s, when the star artist discovered talents and gave visibility to figures like Kenny Scharf, Keith Haring, and later Basquiat. Warhol’s work carried a critique of a society bombarded with consumer objects, presenting artworks based on the reproduction of images of famous personalities, common merchandise, or disasters and deaths, giving a slightly different treatment to each painting he produced along this path. This interest in working with the reproduction of images — even while individualizing each work in the end — can be compared to Banksy’s stencil technique and prints, revealing a particular way of thinking about the production and diffusion of artworks. The influence of Warhol’s humor — present in his works, but perhaps more explicit in his writings and public self-presentation, with his provocative phrases and his leveling way of treating both film stars and car accidents until those images were stripped of their original meanings — is also recognizable in Banksy’s works and presentations, even though the latter constantly seems more aggressive. Warhol knew how to turn himself into an artistic character, always declaredly concerned with the presentation of himself; he was excellent at personal marketing, at approaching illustrious company; he knew how to dress and stay ahead of fashion; he was present at the great social events; and he created a space that was an icon of New York’s artistic culture in the 70s and early 80s, the Factory.

Banksy’s critique of the art market appears different in his film compared with the writings in *Wall and Piece*, where the artist accused the art world of elitism, counterposing and exalting graffiti. In *Exit Through the Gift Shop*, on the other hand — perhaps precisely because of this proximity to Andy Warhol, clear in Banksy’s works

and especially in Mr. Brainwash's — his questioning comes to focus more on fame and on the processes of value-legitimation based on appearance, on the spectacle that can promote anything — while he achieves still more celebrity satirizing the very market that sustains his projects, remaining ambiguous. Unlike many artists of his era who wanted to go against the media, especially against television, Warhol played with them, affirming that his greatest dream had always been to have his own TV program, which would be called "Nothing Special" — though it was called "Andy Warhol's TV" when realized. Warhol recognized himself as a child of the television generation, without thereby ceasing to be ironic about the necessities of consumption; and precisely because he knew how to play with social logics, his work induces reflection on and contestation of them.

Andy Warhol also produced many experimental films, which frequently were not easily marketable even though the artist was already well recognized when he released them. Some of his friends and assistants recount in interviews⁵¹ how Warhol seemed to want to film everything and everyone around him, going so far as to produce films showing friends like John Giorno sleeping for five hours, or a feature of more than eight hours showing the New York skyscraper the Empire State Building — which in a certain way recalls Thierry Guetta's compulsion to film everything he can. In 1964 Warhol even produced a curious television program called "The Lester Persky Story," in which we see a silent sequence of what appears to be a sentimental film without a clear narrative, intercut with television advertisements with sound — the name of the advertising supplier was Lester Persky: "The ads were the most important thing, with their strong messages like: 'Mom no longer needs to worry about body odor.' The reality of television. Real television."⁵² In the only released TV episode of "The Antics Roadshow" (2011), which Banksy produced for Britain's Channel 4, advertisements also gain relevance — comic announcements for other, nonexistent TV programs, such as "Embarrassing Bodies." The episode presents itself as a series about "bad behavior in public space," showing different types of illegal public acts, some with artistic intention, some political, others without a clear purpose — like a man who broke into the English royal residence and visited the queen's bedroom just to look.

"I always suspected I was watching TV instead of living life,"⁵³ Andy Warhol himself once stated. A phrase like this lets us glimpse how much the apparatuses that diffuse images, sounds, and information change our way of perceiving reality, of conceiving what is possible or what can be imagined/fantasized. Banksy's focus remains the street and the artistic and/or political productions made in urban space, but his way of approaching this space is blended with his use of various media — even when he leaves a stencil in the street (and his team alerts some journalist to its location by

⁵¹BENHAMOU-HUET, Judith (org.), op. cit.

⁵²BENHAMOU-HUET, Judith (org.), op. cit.

⁵³BENHAMOU-HUET, Judith (org.), op. cit.

e-mail) or organizes a painting event, as with the “Cans Festival” in London, 2008, or the Santa’s Ghetto in Bethlehem in 2007. Even when referring to painted works in public space, Banksy states that his images painted in the street are like frozen scenes from films playing in his head,⁵⁴ and recently on his website he posted that a good part of his stencils are conceived in relation to an observer in a moving vehicle.⁵⁵ He is a young artist — at least according to what he publicly states — and considering the curtain of anonymity, many suspect that the man who began painting around Bristol no longer conceives his works or his statements alone. His work may yet take other directions that come to re-signify his earlier production; but at present, given the very importance of his trajectory’s visibility and critical position, I see in Banksy’s work a strong path for thinking the connections between the physical space of the city and its interweaving with the various media that populate our everyday life.

⁵⁴“The art I make is similar to film — my paintings are essentially freeze frames from movies that are playing in my head. I think it’s pretty clear that film is the pre-eminent art form of our age.” Banksy interview with the blog All These Wonderful Things, 2010; see bibliography.

⁵⁵Published in the FAQ section: “What do you say to people who claim the way you express yourself is crass, dumb and simplistic? Well duh. They’re right of course. Most of this stuff is designed to be viewed from a moving vehicle.” — <http://www.banksy.co.uk/QA/qaa.html> — accessed June 2012.

Chapter 4 — The Works and the Media

“If there is something that might be useful to describe the present relations between art and photography, it is the unresolved tension that has been formed between the two by the photography of artworks.”⁵⁶ (Walter Benjamin, *Piccola storia della fotografia*)

Over the black screen, white letters — thin and trembling — appear with the title “Muto” (‘mute’ in Italian, meaning a mute person, or ‘I change’). The video begins; we hear the sound of cars in the distance; we see daybreak in stop-motion on an ordinary street of the Argentine capital, Buenos Aires. The scene shifts, always in stop-motion, to the side of the street, following a long wall of reddish bricks where some paintings and writing can be seen. The sound of something cracking is heard: a white brick seems to sketch a movement; then it is pushed out of the wall and falls, leaving a trail of white paint in its path. But the brick did not really move across the public surface; it is the effect of successive layers of paint with the stop-motion filming technique that gives the impression that a painting on the wall can really move.

The camera approaches the dark void left in the brick’s place, and the hand of a white being with black outlines seems to want to emerge from some recess inside the wall — several hands follow it, and we see an animal composed of many arms and nothing else come out of the small space of a single brick, only to fall clumsily to the ground. The music begins — an abstract beat made on a computer that leaves room for the sounds of the strange beings that keep appearing throughout the video. The many-armed animal walks a little, leaving its countless dirty-white trails; a single large eye erupts at the top of this creature, which then meets another like itself coming from the opposite direction; their arms combine; they turn into a third being whose teeth come to life and run off across the street’s pavement. One tooth reaches another wall, and out of it comes a man with an enormous faceless head — a head that sneezes, falls to the ground and breaks, turning into a geometric form; sneezes again and breaks once more, becomes something else, and something else again, until it takes the form of a box that will multiply until it occupies the man’s whole body. At this moment the camera approaches and soon pulls back: we are faced with the same box-being, but the wall is already another; we are now on a busier street, and the transformations of the beings on the walls continue regardless of the distracted passersby.

The changes of the painted beings seem infinite as they walk along the city’s walls, jumping from one to another with a slight camera movement, or even taking advantage of cracks and openings to enter an enclosed space — what could that wide, bright, yet neglected room be, containing almost nothing besides a few white papers placed

⁵⁶“If there is something that might be useful to describe the present relations between art and photography, it is the unreleased tension that has been formed between the two by the photography of artworks” — in MAZZOLA, Roberta. “Castelgrande.” Available at: <http://www.varini.org/04tex/texa10.html> — accessed May 2012.

on the wall? While we are in this closed place, the paintings even take the form of a man of approximately human scale in work clothes, with tie, glasses, and a briefcase; but soon the man's head detaches from his body and walks off on mechanical spider legs, and from the head emerges a larva that heads back toward the entrance to the city. The painted beings have the freedom to take whatever scale they wish — they can be minute, or so large that only a detail of them appears on the side of a building; they can be men, machines, or strange creatures — but their final transformation takes the form of insects, fat ants, which eat a human face leaving only a skull.

Produced over three months between 2007 and 2008 in Buenos Aires and in Baden, Germany, *Muto* is a project conceived by the Italian artist from Bologna known as Blu, with music by Andrea Martignoni, from the same city. It is not possible to pinpoint at what moment in the video we are transported from the Argentine capital to the German city — there are no clear indications — but judging by the writing and posters on the city walls, most of the scenes in open locations seem to have been made in Argentina. The camera heightens the sensation of constant change and uncertainty by always moving, as if each frame came from a photo taken in a slightly different position, changing settings at any moment. Nor is it possible to tell from the video how many days of filming appear; but the light is always varying and the clouds moving in the background, giving the impression of the day passing, even though it never ends. The project was released at several international short-film festivals — I myself saw it for the first time at a festival at MAM-RJ in 2008 — but its widest diffusion occurred through the site Youtube.com, an informal platform for watching and sharing videos on any subject. The internet is an essential platform in this artist's work, for the publicizing and exhibition of his videos and photos, but also for his very presentation of himself and his continuous updating of his blog: his official site (www.blublu.org) has the layout of a sketchbook, presenting pages of videos, another of murals, one of drawings, one with a link to the site selling works and books about the artist, and the blog on which the artist frequently reports his activities, usually succinctly, since July 2010 (he previously had another blog, apparently no longer online).

Blu was already an artist of international relevance, above all in the urban art scene, when he released "*Muto*," his first finished project of animation on walls — which he claims is only a test.⁵⁷ His fame came from his taste for producing large-scale murals, occupying entire sides of multi-story buildings in various cities of the world, having taken part in exhibitions such as the Tate Gallery's "Street Art" show of 2008. He draws on the great walls as if he were in the intimacy of his sketchbook: a drawing of thin black lines, with few colors and almost no shadows. The artist may take inspiration from earlier drawings when deciding to paint a wall, but his wall drawings always rely on the improvisation of the moment; and in his making-of videos one can see his precision in making the outlines of a figure using a brush, an extension pole,

⁵⁷Interview published in the book *Beyond the Street*; see bibliography.

and a ladder — up close one can see the flaws in the lines of his walls, but looking at the whole one has the impression that the walls are like the pages of his sketchbook. In one of his first interviews, given in 2004 to the Wooster Collective, he describes his work as “some ironic and bizarre sketches about modern life (painted on public walls),”⁵⁸ and tells how he is inspired by what happens around him, trying to think about ways of living and the nonsense of everyday life.

Having begun as a graffiti writer, writing tags and using spray cans, he is said to have learned to draw by copying underground comic magazines, with the art of Robert Crumb or Roland Topor; but his influences range across different groups in the history of art — the Situationists, Hokusai, Bosch, Haring — and, among more recent artists, Banksy and Osgemeos. But there is a whole particular universe of his own that gradually took shape: an anguishing world, full of rounded hairless men who frequently have their heads cut off and their insides exposed, along with mythological characters, weapons, and beings that pursue or transform into other beings. In the documentary “Megunica,” directed by Lorenzo Fonda and released in 2008, one can follow the journey of Blu (always with his back turned) and three friends through Mexico, Nicaragua, Guatemala, Costa Rica, and Argentina, showing up close the Italian artist’s production on walls and sketchbooks, along with interviews with people who crossed the group’s path and fantastical animations that play with the filmed scenes. In one of the scenes, when boys leaf through one of Blu’s sketchbooks and ask what the drawings mean, he replies to the curious that his marks have no fixed meanings; they are free images of his mind that can be interpreted however the observer prefers. In another scene, while making a mural that took up the side of more than one building in Buenos Aires, the artist explains that one of the reasons he paints in public space is the opportunity to take advantage of the elements it offers; thus the whole drawing of the wall he was making had started from a small solitary window, transformed into the eye of an enormous figure housing dozens of floors of rooms with little men in varied activities. Hence the position of the being he was painting was also the fruit of the very configuration of the buildings: “that was the skeleton of this mural,” Blu says near the film’s conclusion.⁵⁹ (fig. 13)

⁵⁸Interview available at <http://www.woostercollective.com/post/profile-blu> — accessed February 2012.

⁵⁹FONDA, Lorenzo. *Megunica*. Mercurio Films, 2008.



Fig. 13 — 2007, Blu, mural painting in public space, Buenos Aires.

When asked by a journalist whether his work is a kind of collaboration with a preexisting structure, he answers: “Yes and no. Because in a sense each wall already tells the whole story; it’s all there. I only happen upon it.”⁶⁰ In another interview, Blu explained that when painting he tries to imitate the way Gordon Matta-Clark used a building as if it were a sculpture.⁶¹ The relation of Blu’s work to Matta-Clark’s may not be very clear at first, but it is quite present in the way the Italian tries to think the space he occupies. Matta-Clark has been a continuous influence on the production of art in public places since the 1970s, even though he also operated largely within artistic institutions in exhibitions. Matta-Clark’s interest in producing works that altered our perceptions of places and situations considered banal, in working with the architecture of disprized constructions, is also visible in the works of Blu, who usually chooses neglected surfaces where he can play with the elements of the landscape. Matta-Clark was bothered by the attitude he noticed in many architects, who saw a decaying building merely as a structure to be removed in the interest of renewing urban planning, replacing old architecture with new architecture likewise not made to last. According to that artist, modern architecture did not meet people’s needs, for it created dehumanized spaces — and for many of those who paint in public spaces, above all illegally, one of the strongest goals is precisely to humanize a decaying place.

Matta-Clark made his work function in relation to the surrounding urban environ-

⁶⁰ZEVIN, Alexander. “Against the Wall: Blu Paints Giants in Buenos Aires.” Published in *The Argentina Independent*, January 26, 2007. Available at: <http://www.argentinaindependent.com/the-arts/art/against-the-wall-blu-paints-giants-in-buenos-aires/> — accessed May 2012.

⁶¹LEWISOHN, Cedar, op. cit.

ment, without denying its political and cultural contradictions, distancing himself from the conception common among modern architects who thought of a building as self-sufficient. By making his works in public places during the day, they became a kind of demolition spectacle for casual pedestrians, functioning in a certain way as “agit-prop” — in a manner not so different from artists like Blu, who also leave space open for people to approach while they work, creating moments of exchange of ideas. Matta-Clark was also interested in the tagging graffiti of 1970s New York, documenting what he called photoglyphs in 1973, which he assembled into rolls more than ten meters long, imitating the exterior of a subway car. In 1973 he also made the work “Graffiti Truck,” in which residents of the Bronx were offered the opportunity to graffiti a truck the artist had acquired.⁶²

Matta-Clark is best known, however, for his “building cuts,” in which he produced voids of varied shapes in the walls and floors of abandoned buildings — or buildings soon to be abandoned — to create spatial conditions that could radically alter the observer’s perception of that architecture and the surrounding environment. The result was the transformation of the everyday experience of the building into a visual and kinetic confrontation: passages and views were created in the edifice without clear functions, contesting the very practical functionality of architecture. In the early 1970s, Matta-Clark was interested in the idea of entropy, as well as in the Situationists’ *détournement* (the re-signification of imagery from mass culture); his gestures in architecture had the potential to be statements against certain social conditions that were objectified by the positions of modernist architecture. Although he was an architect trained at the renowned Cornell University, he preferred to create an *anarchitecture* — a wordplay used with different senses, designating a collective of artists to which Gordon Matta-Clark belonged, as well as his own conceptions, which generally opposed the ideals of modern architecture.

One of his most ambitious projects was “Splitting,” of 1974, in which the artist used a wooden house in Englewood, New Jersey — a dwelling destined to be destroyed by its owners, Horace and Holly Solomon. Matta-Clark split the house in half starting from the center of the

⁶²LEWISOHN, Cedar, op. cit. house along two parallel lines, documented the whole process, and made a sculptural extraction, cutting off the four upper corners of the house. The final work would be a kind of constructed ruin, a dissection of the architectural structure that reveals layers of meaning — social, architectural, and familial-anthropological. The work inspires us to rethink the American dream of the nuclear family, or the notions of security and shelter, by revealing the building’s layers, the concrete, the wallpaper. Dan Graham, commenting on this work, stresses that the cuts could make articulations proper to the space of the house, but the building’s identity was rigorously preserved, for Matta-Clark sought out the voids that already existed and had not been explored; and exposing such voids became a denunciation of professional architectural practice, an inversion of its functionalist doctrine.[⁶⁶] The cuts also show the way inhabitants occupy compartmentalized space: tenants adapt to the space imposed by the architect and his developer — that is, to an existing social structure. The work is thus, in a certain way, a sculpture revealing the individual’s counterpart, that subversive memory hidden by social and architectural façades with their false image of integrity. Also according to Graham, what Gordon sought — and what modern architects avoid at all costs — was to reveal to the public the laws of property and the general process of containerization to which urban space is subjected.

The action of “Splitting” was filmed and photographed. Its video was made with 16mm film, lasting approximately ten minutes; there is no sound; as in old silent films, light letters appear on a black background to explain the work’s process — how and where the cut in the building was made — and, at the end, that it lasted three months before its demolition. The camera in Splitting is always shaky; one sees men exerting physical force to operate the instruments performing the cut; there are close-ups of the small openings gradually appearing; special attention is given to the entries of light that form — to the luminosity over the cut, but also to the cut seen together with the whole of the house. The video’s editing is quite simple, with abrupt passages from one scene to another and bits of different frames at times appearing at the corner of the screen. The architectural intervention of “Splitting” itself was not made to be seen by the public: photographs of the project were exhibited at Holly Solomon’s gallery, together with a video and the corners removed from the house. One can say the documentation was the work.

Matta-Clark made several experiments with video, filming his own performances and also works like “City Slivers,” in which he films busy streets and even uses anamorphic lenses, elongating the image. An important question in these videos would be the artist’s limited control over the filmed images and over the juxtaposition of the different sequences, considering that in some cases the editing was done in the camera itself.⁶³ The resulting film would have a random structure that seems to portray well the floating movement of a city’s traffic and pedestrians — which, according to an article by the English artist and academic Paul Landon, evokes the character of the flâneur, a fluid time with an observer distanced even by the absence of sound.

Blu’s approach in his videos no longer has any of this random character, nor the mastery of rudimentary filming devices. If in “Muto” the illusion of animation was already well developed, in “Big Bang Big Boom” his technique seems refined. He no longer limits himself to animating two-dimensional images on surfaces; he animates objects such as cars, plastic bags, and sand; paints entire houses; creates beings with garbage dumped on the beach. The illusion and the interaction with the city’s elements are more potent insofar as the paintings on the walls can transform into three-dimensional objects at any moment, even filling rooms and houses; at one point in the video we see a dinosaur painted on a wall hurl one of the people walking on that same street. As for narrative, that of “Big Bang” is more concise than in his earlier shorts, revealing a story — always violent and fantastical — of life on Earth, in which living beings transform and pursue one another continually until the human kills its own species and a great rocket/bomb explodes the planet.

Although they have come to mix more resources, Blu’s stop-motion animations are

⁶³LANDON, Paul. “Distractions, disinterestedness and daydreaming: How the modern city is depicted in the video Tramage by Jean-François Guillon and in the film City Slivers by Gordon Matta-Clark.” Paper presented at “Problématiques de l’architecture des Nouvelles Formes Narratives en création audio et vidéo,” Montréal, Québec, October 2005.

still focused on the production of two-dimensional paintings on walls: an ancestral technique of creating images and worlds is transformed into moving image by being photographed and presented in its digital reassembly. In the images of the videos, the city, the surface, and the painting have no ontological difference — everything is merely thousands of pixels. Hence, with a good command of the latest image-editing programs, the possibilities of illusion can make anything transform into anything else. Yet this effect of transforming the city into painting and image does not depend on the use of the computer or of video as the work's support. An artist like the Swiss Felice Varini, born in 1952, manages to produce works in which a landscape seems to transform into a two-dimensional image of itself while we are present in that environment. Through calculations and distortions, Varini works with geometric images, spreading their forms across an environment so that, from a given point of view, the distortion produces the optical effect that we are seeing a given flat, two-dimensional form running through the entire landscape.



Fig. 14 — 2009, Felice Varini, “Cercles et suite d’éclats,” intervention in public space, Vercorin, Switzerland.

Invited by the Swiss town of Vercorin, in the Alps, to produce a work in 2009, Varini created a pattern of white circles whose pieces were divided among several houses so that, in the panoramic view of the town, it was possible to see them all whole — a work titled “Cercles et suite d’éclats” (Circles and sequence of fragments/bursts). Would it be possible for a work like this to have been produced or conceived before the dissemination of cameras that transformed any landscape into a potential photo? And even if such interventions do not necessarily require digital technology to be made — though in this case they use it — Varini’s works seem the fruit of an observer who

is at the very least modern. As Jonathan Crary describes in his book already cited in the first chapter, it was at the beginning of the nineteenth century that the study of the physiology of the eye and of afterimages began to be truly deepened, so that the prevailing idea of vision ceased to be based on an epistemological model of the camera obscura (which sees vision as sustained by a geometry of light rays in which the eye simply receives and transmits external information like a lens) and came to consider the particularities proper to the organ of the eye and its susceptibility to illusion. With this modern understanding of vision, image-producing technical apparatuses giving the illusion of reality were progressively developed, such as the stereoscope and photography — on which Varini's work is based. This does not mean that illusionistic images were not created before the nineteenth century, but that the very way of thinking about illusion came to have another focus, less oriented toward a metaphor that makes painting a window, for example.

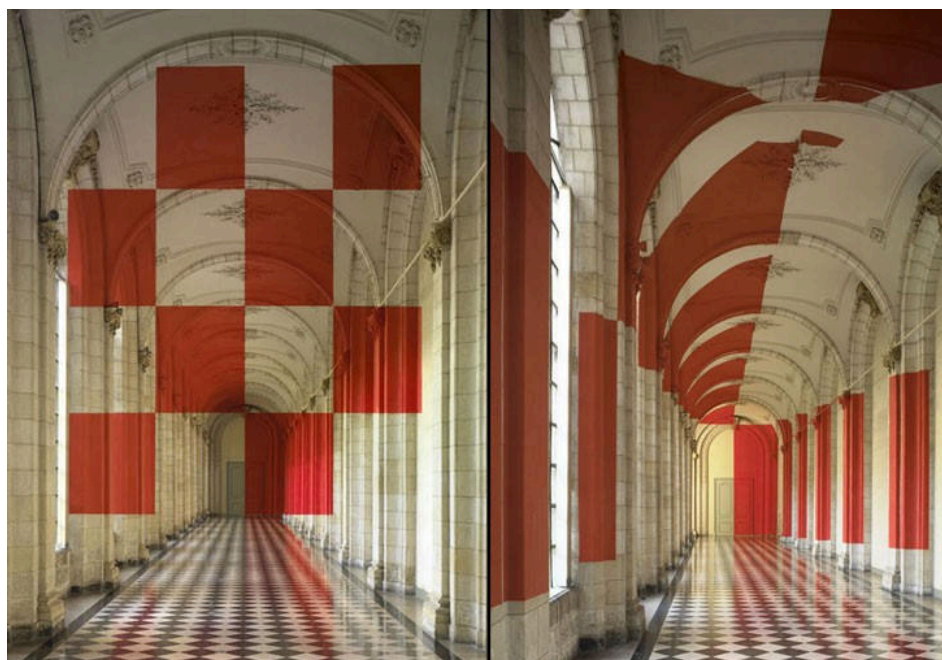


Fig. 15 — 2007, Felice Varini, "Huit rectangles," installation at the Musée des Beaux-Arts, Arras, France.

If a person is not at the vantage point of a Varini work, his pieces can at first be confusing, with forms broken at strange and random angles. Discovering the central point of view while exploring the space of the work is part of its enjoyment, as I had the chance to experience when I came upon an installation of his at the Xippas gallery in Paris, on the recommendation of a Korean friend of mine, Varini's assistant Hyo-Seok Jin. These interventions are made with the use of large image projectors, with photographic references of the site; his painting material uses adhesives. The Swiss artist's work, according to a text by Roberta Mazzola available on his website, concentrates on the problem of the falsity of images in relation to the truth of perception:

“the basic principle consists in juxtaposing two incompatible modes of perception or interpretation, stimulated by the arrangement in space of paintings or photographs, and at the same time in the demonstration that both these modes are merely different visual effects, depending upon the viewpoint of the observer.”⁶⁴

Roberta Mazzola and Johannes Meinhardt⁶⁵ compare the spatial-visual experience of Varini’s work to the strategies of Minimalist art, for its play with objects and with the observer’s perception. Varini would act as a painter in three-dimensional space who violates the spatial essence of architecture — on which painting is based — causing an inversion of the perspectival logic of space toward the two-dimensional image. Mazzola cites Pierre Francastel, in a passage where he affirms painting as a medium increasingly devoted to the analysis of the processes of perception ever since it ceased to be the principal means of reproducing images. For the researcher, the Swiss artist’s work gains force in its capacity — through the spectator’s participation — to explore space as an experience of perception in the “here and now” of the moment. Even so, she analyzes how the photographs of Varini’s interventions made by Pino Brioschi, Jordi Bernadó, André Morin, and Pino Musi manage to capture the works, registering and unfolding in their own way the experience these induce in the observer — a challenge for photographic practice in its relation to artworks: “Connected by its genesis to the uniqueness of the situation of reference, photography brings out the close link between the work and the context, while reflecting, not in an impartial way, a concept of temporal experience of the work.”⁶⁶ Even though Varini’s work is strongly focused on the spectator’s presence in a given place, in many of his exhibitions it is the photographs that are shown — though I believe that in this artist’s case, presence remains the most potent form of enjoying the work.

Moving on to yet another way of using photography and the physical space of the city, one can consider the trajectory of Space Invader, one of the most famous urban artists today. His works have been exhibited in some major museums, such as MASP in 2011, but he became known for his mosaic paste-ups representing figures from the world-famous 1990s computer game of the same name. Seeing one of his mosaics in the street might be a curious element for a person who happened to notice it without knowing anything of its history; but on learning that the artist spreads his mosaics through unexpected places in a city, photographs each one, and then presents them on his website as points on an interactive map — defined as the record of the game’s invasion of the city — then recognizing one of this man’s works in the street takes on much more force. Space’s website presents itself as an alien game invading cities in every part of the world, from Paris to Hong Kong, Sydney, and São Paulo, with elements of different point values depending on the size of the placed work. If a spectator becomes interested in some work, they can acquire it through his site, receiving

⁶⁴MAZZOLA, Roberta, op. cit.

⁶⁵Text also available on Varini’s official website; see bibliography.

⁶⁶MAZZOLA, Roberta, op. cit.

at home a photograph of the chosen work in the street plus a mosaic identical to the one in the photo and a map of the artist's invasion of the city — and they can also buy his other varieties of work at the galleries that represent him.



Fig. 16 — 2008, Space Invader, mosaic installation in public space, Kathmandu, Nepal.

There are many ways of connecting the walk through the city with its digital counterpart. For this, a directly artistic intention is not necessarily required — as with the proliferation of QR codes ('quick response' barcodes) through cities, whose rapid reading, for those using camera phones, allows passersby to access websites, videos, texts, or images contained in the code. There have even been cases of people tattooing these symbols on their bodies, like the animated tattoo made by the French tattoo artist Karl Marc in 2011.⁶⁷ A profusion of artists also deals with the digital image cast into urban space, like Miguel Chevalier's beautiful artificial greenhouse, mounted in a square in Rio de Janeiro in 2011, in which we see digital animations of flowers that look pixelated, or the projections of the Graffiti Research Lab collective and of Simone Michelin — even so, most of the works I analyze render sharper the tension between the two-dimensional image of painting, photography, and spatial presence.

Recalling the work of Matta-Clark or of the pioneers of Land Art — and one could go further back — one can think of a path within the visual arts in which the enjoyment of a work that also exists in physical space always occurs mixed with its technical images. The work of an artist like Blu presents several similarities with such predecessors, but his videos and paintings are made already with their diffusion through the internet — and the legion of observers connected to it — in mind. Perhaps one can even say that this fact alone is enough to change the narrative and rhythm of an audiovisual or

⁶⁷This work can be seen at <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=f3qv2dSXQXk> or on the artist's site <http://www.karlmarc.com/index.html>

plastic production, since the time and attention of someone moving between websites, on their computer or another device, would already be conditioned differently from those of someone who sees videos and photos in an art exhibition.

“The art of the past no longer exists as it once did. Its authority is lost. In its place there is a language of images. What matters now is who uses that language for what purpose.”⁶⁸ This sentence opens the last paragraph of an essay by John Berger first published in 1972 in the book *Ways of Seeing*, which analyzes the continuities and discontinuities of advertising and photography in relation to artworks prior to technical reproducibility. Whether the innovations in the technological apparatuses that produce and diffuse images are influencing — altering — our ways of seeing and producing images as strongly as, for example, the expansion of cinema did at the beginning of the twentieth century is a question to be developed with more calm; but I hope through this text to have presented at least a glimpse of how some artists have been playing with this process.

⁶⁸BERGER, John. *Ways of Seeing*. London: BBC and Penguin Books, 2000, p. 33. visual one?

Final Considerations

Once, while I was coordinating and painting in a collective mural project, one of the pioneers of graffiti in Rio de Janeiro, Akuma, gave me the tip of taking photos of my painting on the wall, so that in the photograph I could more easily see the contrasts, the balance of the drawing and the colors. A few months earlier I had bought a smart-phone for the first time, which also changed my way of painting on the wall — not only because I could follow Akuma's advice whenever I wished, taking phone photos at any time, but also because I could use my photographs or images from the internet as reference — at least as long as my phone battery allowed. These are habits and perceptions we construct with ease as soon as we incorporate a new element — in this case, a device — into our everyday life.

Reproduction, both in print and on the screens of various electronic devices, has allowed images of art to become ephemeral, ubiquitous, insubstantial, available. John Berger goes so far as to affirm that images surround us the way language does, commenting on how they have entered the mainstream of life. Or we could think of W. J. T. Mitchell's "pictorial turn" and its way of opening the question of how theoretical reflections on images are sustained by social and cultural practices, whose history would be fundamental for understanding not only what images are, but what the human being is and what it can become. Authors like Oliver Grau, as well as Jonathan Crary, also alert us to the speed with which the world of images surrounding us is changing, especially as regards its mode of production — both authors stressing the specificity of three-dimensional images calculated by computers.

By bringing this problematic to the city through certain works of art and their tensions, I hope to incite reflection on the everyday adaptations in the way artistic works are produced and enjoyed, within the process Pierre Lévy calls virtualization, intensified by the use of certain technological apparatuses. Throughout this text I have sought to focus on works that have an ambiguous relation to the observer's presence before an original or its reproductions — the case of site-specific works would render the ambiguity sharper insofar as it mixes with a particular relation of the work to a given spatial context, while at the same time the work (and perhaps one can say our very perception of space) is also unfolded in its transformation/appropriation into media of technical reproduction, such as video and photography. At a moment of re-dimensioning of distances both physical and communicational, what can it mean to think space and to transform it (or project upon it) into an image

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